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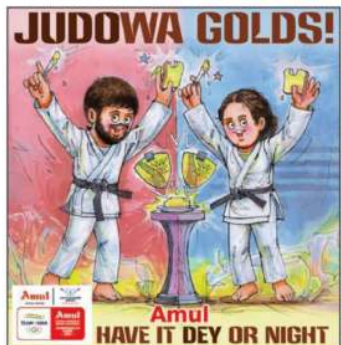
CHENNAI • MONDAY • AUGUST 03, 2020 • ₹9.00 • PAGES 16 • LATE CITY EDITION



Rescue workers evacuating people from their flooded homes at Moothikkal in Kozhikode, Kerala has reported 11 deaths after torrential rains triggered landslides and floods. The state is bracing for heavy rainfall on Monday | VINCENT PULLICKAL | P5

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Five killed as car rams parked lorry in Kovai

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Coimbatore

FIVE persons, including four members of a family, were killed after the car they were travelling in rammed into a stationary water tanker lorry on the Pollachi-Udumalpet Road in Coimbatore on Sunday afternoon.

The deceased were identified as Kanagaraj E (42), his wife Boomamaheshwari K (42), their daughters, Aarthi K (24) and Namrutha K (21), all residents of MLA Street at Kurumbapalayam near Madukkarai, and their neighbour, Ramu A (38) of Madukkarai, who was driving the car.



Mangled remains of the car | EXPRESS

pm, their speeding car crashed into the rear of the lorry, which had been parked along the roadside near Nallampalli Pirivu to water plants. All five occupants died on the spot.

On receiving information, the Gomangalam police recovered the bodies and sent them to Pollachi Government Hospital for postmortem. A police officer said the family might have been on their way back home after visiting the Murugan temple in Palani as pooja items were found inside the car and Kanagaraj had consumed his food.

A case has been registered under BNS sections 106(1) and 281 and further probe is under way.

Govt launches 100-wk drive against drugs

PM exhorts youth to take pledge against drug abuse for 'Viksit Bharat'

RAJESH KUMAR THAKUR @ New Delhi

PRIME Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asked the country's youth to take a pledge against substance abuse, saying drugs can give them a "high" for some time, but would make their entire career and personal life "low".

Launching the 'Nasha Mukta Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan', a 100-week campaign against drugs, Modi said that youngsters must be protected from the grip of addiction as the nation marches towards the goal of a 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047. "When the country has set the goal of building a developed India, it is essential that the youth stay away from harmful addictions to remain physically and mentally healthy and full of self-confidence," Modi said.

Speaking after virtually launching the nationwide campaign, he called for open communication within families to prevent young members from falling into the vicious cycle of addiction, and assured the youth that the government stands firmly with them in this battle.

He highlighted unprecedented nationwide crackdowns, massive seizures of narcotics worth thousands of crores, and a sharp rise in arrests of drug dealers and smugglers. He urged families to seek timely medical help without worrying about stigma and highlighted the role of societal support, yoga, meditation and rehabilitation centres. "If a youth has mistakenly fallen into addiction, it absolutely does not mean that all their paths are permanently closed," Modi said.

The prime minister appealed to college and university professors to discuss perils of drug abuse alongside regular coursework and help build a strong anti-addiction movement on campuses.

Outlining the campaign's roadmap, Modi said every Sunday for the next 100 weeks would feature dedicated activities centred on art, culture, sports and meditation. "The coming 100 Sundays will absolutely become 100 strong steps in the direction of a completely drug-free India," he said.



One can get rid of substance abuse with the support of society, yoga and meditation — it's essential youth stay away from harmful addictions

Narendra Modi, PM



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EXPRESS READ

Tot beaten to death by mom's partner

Virudhunagar: A three-year-old girl was beaten to death allegedly by her mother's partner at Thiruthangal in Sivakasi on Sunday. Police said the accused, K Vigneshwaran, assaulted the girl claiming she was a hindrance to his relationship with her mother. He has been arrested and booked for murder | P2

TN minister alleges Stalin-DKS nexus

Chennai: Law Minister CTR Nirmal Kumar on Sunday alleged that there existed a close nexus between DMK president MK Stalin and Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, and claimed that it was undermining Tamil Nadu's interests in the Cauvery water dispute | P4

Long after probe, 158 exam cases await trial

MUKESH RANJAN @ New Delhi

AT least 158 cases linked to alleged irregularities in recruitment and entrance examinations are awaiting trial in various courts despite the completion of the CBI probe, sources said, adding that some of the cases have been pending for more than two decades.

The CBI has now decided to approach high courts, requesting that these long-pending cases be shifted to the new Special Fast-Track Courts being established under the newly passed anti-paper leak law.

Delhi accounts for nearly 25 such cases, some dating back to 2000, in which investigations have been completed, but trials are yet to begin. These include alleged irregularities in the AIIMS PG entrance examination (2010-11), the Delhi University

Medical and Dental Entrance Examination (2011), the Common Admission Test (CAT) (2004), the Staff Selection Commission (SSC) recruitment (2013), and teachers' recruitment examinations.

Bihar has five pending cases, including three linked to the alleged NEET-UG 2024 paper leak, besides two cases relating to the Pre-Medical Test (PMT) examinations of 2003 and 2011, sources said. Other states with significant pendency include Jharkhand and Karnataka with five cases each, Maharashtra with three, including two related to the alleged NEET-UG 2024 paper leak, Rajasthan with eight, Tamil Nadu with 14 and Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal with 10 cases each. In Himachal Pradesh, three cases, including the 2022 police constable recruitment exam, are awaiting trial.

25 CASES

awaiting trial in Delhi. These include the AIIMS PG recruitment examination of 2010-11 and Delhi University Medical and Dental Entrance of 2011

Push for speedy trial

The CBI will convey to high courts that it will provide dedicated special prosecutors to conduct trials and ensure all resources are available to finish them faster



CW6 2030

Over to Amdavad after Glasgow show

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Chennai

OVER the past 10 months, Amdavad has quietly been witness to a lot of sporting complexes come up. It has also

GLASGOW 2026



jarat's deputy chief minister, Harsh Sanghavi, were present.

If the 22nd edition of the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow was truncated, the 23rd edition could possibly be its

Fourth place for India

Despite many key sports like wrestling &

hosted a wide variety of international events to show to the sporting world that its doors are open.

Sometime between now and 2030, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) will announce the host city for the 2036 Games. But in 2030, Amma will be decked up as it welcomes the athletes and other non-playing staff from over 70 countries and territories for the next edition of the Commonwealth Games. That wait ended on Sunday night in Glasgow as the Closing Ceremony saw Scotland handing over the CWG flag and host baton to India. Dignitaries including Gu-



CS president Donald Rukare with Gujarat Deputy CM Harsh Sanghani | P

monwealth Games. That wait ended on Sunday night in Glasgow as the Closing Ceremony saw Scotland handing over the CWG flag and host baton to India. Dignitaries including Gu-

biggest and grandest in terms of scale, number of athletes and ambition. The staging of the Games will be seen as a spectacle, further proof that India is capable of putting together a grand showpiece.

With the city's Olympic-sized plans, governments at all levels as well as bureaucrats will want to leave no stone unturned to ensure there are no scandals or controversies like in 2010.

missing, the athletes beat expectations as India finished fourth with 39 medals (13 gold, 17 silver, nine bronze). Of the 13, women won eight gold medals, a praiseworthy achievement.

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TAMIL NADU

02 CHENNAI

MONDAY 03.08.2026

ALMANAC TODAY

Monday: 03/08/2026 • Year: Parashva • Aadi: The Pira • Ashade: Krishna Paksha • Tithi: Panchami 18:22 Shra • Nakshatra (Star): U. Bhadrapada 12:20th, Moon in Meen • Rahu-kalam: 01:30-09:00 • Yamagantam: 10:30-12:00 • Gulika-kalam: 13:30-15:00



28°C MIN 34°C MAX
FORECAST
Light rain

Sunrise: 05:55 am
Sunset: 06:36 pm
Moonrise: 09:48 pm
Moonset: 10:27 am

newindianexpress.com

B. ANBUSELVAN @Chennai

THE state highways department has completed around 70% of the four-lane elevated corridor on Anna Salai and is planning to open it by the end of November.

The 3.2-km project, touted as the country's first elevated corridor to be built directly above an operational metro tunnel, is being built using prefabricated steel components. As the flyover runs above the underground metro line, the engineering complexity has pushed up the project cost to ₹621 crore, making it costlier than a conventional highway project. The project is expected to reduce travel time between Teynampet and Saidapet on Anna Salai from about 30 minutes to just five minutes. It will also ease congestion at seven major intersections — Eldams Road, SIET College Road, Cenotaph Road, Nandanam, CIT Nagar, CIT Nagar 1st Main Road (towards T Nagar), and Jones Road.

According to sources, around 1.5 km of the flyover has been completed, while 46 of the total 69 piers have been erected. The Teynampet-Saidapet metro tunnel runs 14 to 15 metres beneath Anna Salai. To avoid disturbing the tunnel, the highways department drilled only up to a depth of seven metres from the road surface to lay the flyover's foundations. Of the total 3.2-km stretch, 2.4 km passes directly above the metro tunnel, including a 460-metre stretch over the Teynampet and Nandanam metro stations. The remaining 655 metres is along the non-metro stretch.

"Out of the total 69 piers, 46 have already been erected. Reinforced concrete deck slabs

Anna Salai elevated corridor on track for November launch

70% of work complete on India's first flyover built above an operational metro tunnel; travel time between Teynampet and Saidapet set to shrink from 30 mins to five mins



have been laid for about 2 km of the 3.2-km corridor. Of the 69 piers, 22 are on the non-metro stretch, while 41 portal frames covering the 460-metre section are being installed above the two metro stations. As of August 1, around 70% of the project has been completed," a senior highways official said.

The project, originally scheduled for completion by September this year, was delayed mainly due to a shortage of labour. "A large number of workers engaged in the fabrication of steel components had returned to their native places during the elections in April and did not come back immediately slowing down production. They have now resumed work. Since construction activities at the site in Chennai are permitted only for six hours during the night, progress was initially slow. However, work has now gathered pace, and the project is expected to be completed by the end of November," the official added.

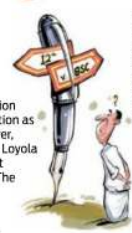
Around 15,000 tonnes of prefabricated steel components, including piers, pier caps and girders, are being manufactured at factories in Gujarat and Telangana, and transported to Chennai for assembly. In addition, RCC deck segments, each measuring about 15 metres in length, are being transported to the site and placed over the girders.

S. Varadarajan, a regular commuter from T Nagar, said, "Traffic diversions caused by both the flyover construction and Chennai Metro Rail Phase-II works have resulted in severe congestion on Anna Salai. The highways department should expedite the remaining works to minimise inconvenience to motorists."

OFF THE CUFF

Degrees of doubt

A controversy is brewing over two official records that are at odds on the chief minister's educational qualifications. The profile of C. Joseph Vijay on the National e-Vidhan Application (NEVA) portal lists his highest qualification as 'BSc'. His 2026 election affidavit, however, describes him as a 'BSc (Dropout)' from Loyola College, Chennai, and records his highest educational qualification as 12th Pass. The discrepancy has given a section of activists fresh ammunition, with demands for an explanation. After all, when official records disagree, someone eventually has to face the test.



-Praveena SA

Hold your horses

Many are grumbling about petrol prices, hiked soon after the state elections. But one Zomato delivery partner appears to have found an alternative by thinking outside the box and saddling up instead. The rider, complete with Zomato's trademark red delivery bag, was recently spotted using four-legged horsepower to trot through the suburbs. Perhaps he steered clear of the city centre, where even the horse might have run out of patience in traffic. For a brief while, food delivery seemed to have galloped back a couple of centuries. Whether he is simply a horse enthusiast or this was a one-off ride remains a mystery. One thing is certain: while some customers got dinner, everyone else got a show.

-Subashini Vijayakumar

When deposits don't mature

Now that the former AIADMK district strongman has left the party, Pudukkottai's whisper network has spread a story that comes with a hefty price tag. Former Alangudi candidate Dhana Vimal has alleged that the ex-minister, now with TVK, failed to return ₹4 crore of the ₹4.5 crore he claims to have paid as a "safe deposit" for an Assembly ticket. The complaint follows an AIADMK district meeting where functionaries resolved to pursue such matters legally. The strongman's loyalists say he acted on the instructions of the party leadership, while detractors claim that any money collected was entirely his own doing.

-Pearson Lenekar SR

(Compiled by Dinesh Jefferson E)

State to withdraw cases booked against students during anti-NEET stir

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @Chennai

THE Tamil Nadu government will withdraw all police cases registered against students who participated in the anti-NEET protests held in July. School Education Minister A. Rajmohan announced on Sunday, saying the decision was taken on the directions of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay.

In a post on X, Rajmohan said that as per the directions of the CM, all cases registered against students who protested against NEET will be withdrawn.

The protests in Tamil Nadu were triggered after Delhi Police cracked down on students demonstrating at Jantar Mantar on July 20 in support of the Cockercock Janta Party's (CJP) anti-NEET agitation.

In Chennai, student organisations launched solidarity protests the same night. After police allegedly denied permission for demonstrations in pub-

lic places, CPI opened its state headquarters, Balan Illam in T Nagar, where students staged a sit-in.

Members of the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), both part of the CJP's protest committee in Delhi, also organised protests at Rajarathnam Stadium.

The TVK government faced criticism for denying permission for public demonstrations and detaining protesters, including SFI and DYFI student leaders from Madurai Kamaraj University ahead of a planned protest.

"Even during the protests, we questioned why the government was denying permission or trying to stop demonstrations when its stand is also against NEET. At least three cases were registered against us. We see the decision to withdraw them as a positive step," said S. Mrithula, state president of SFI.



A. Rajmohan

Tasmac may float online tenders for fresh bar licence this month

S. GURUVANMIKANATHAN @Chennai

TASMAC is likely to float online tenders for new bar licences in the second week of August. The corporation plans to use the fresh licensing drive to begin a modernisation effort at bars attached to its outlets in Chennai, Tiruchy, Madurai and Coimbatore, senior officials told TNIE.

Following repeated complaints from consumers about poor sanitation, inadequate seating, substandard food, lack of drinking water and limited parking at several bars, Tasmac is discussing minimum standards for customer amenities before the new licences are issued.

As part of the exercise, the corporation is also considering allowing cooking facilities inside bars for the first time, a long-standing demand of bar owners. "At present, cooking is prohibited and stoves are not allowed inside bars. However, inspections have found many bars violating the rule by using stoves. Bar owners have been urging the government to permit cooking facilities. Certain



FILE PIC

conditions relating to this issue may be incorporated in the new tender document. However, no final decision has been taken so far," an official said.

Alongside the bar licences, Tasmac is also set to invite a separate online tender for collecting empty liquor bottles under its bottle buy-back scheme. The state has directed the corporation to submit a comprehensive report covering both the licensing process and the bottle collection scheme.

"Tasmac plans to complete the preparatory work in the first week of August. Online tenders for both bar licences

and empty bottle collection are likely to be floated in the second week of August," the official said.

The fresh licensing exercise comes after around 2,600 bars across the state were granted a two-month extension to facilitate the tender process.

"The existing licences expired on June 30, and bar owners were given a two-month extension, which will end in August. Fresh licences will therefore be issued through a tender process, and the newly licensed bars are expected to commence operations in September," the official added.

Three-yr-old girl beaten to death, mom's partner held

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @Virudhunagar

A three-year-old girl was allegedly beaten to death by her mother's partner at Thiruthangal near Sivakasi in Virudhunagar district on Sunday. The victim, D. Vishnu Priya, was the daughter of Dural Pandi and D. Swathi (22) of Chinnalappatti village near Sattur, police said.

According to the police, Swathi had been in a relationship with her co-worker, K. Vigneshwaran (27), at a fireworks manufacturing unit. Following a dispute with her husband four months ago, she had been living with her daughter and Vigneshwaran in Sattur for the past three months. The trio shifted to Sivakasi last month.

Police said Vigneshwaran had allegedly been quarrelling with Swathi and assaulting the child over the past month, claiming that Vishnu Priya was an obstacle to their relationship.

On Saturday night, another quarrel broke out before the family went to sleep. In the early hours of Sunday, the child, who was crying in pain from her injuries, was allegedly assaulted again by Vigneshwaran, after



D. Vishnu Priya

which she lost consciousness.

Police said the accused allegedly locked the house and briefly prevented Swathi from taking the child to hospital. He later allowed her to take the girl to a nearby private hospital, where doctors advised that she be shifted to the Government Hospital. However, Vishnu Priya died on the way. The body was sent to the Virudhunagar Government Medical College Hospital for postmortem. Sivakasi East police registered a case and arrested Vigneshwaran.

Horoscopes By Holiday

HOLIDAY MATRIS

03rd August: Cosmic Oil Can Do You keep asking a question you already have the answer to.



ARIES (Mar 21-Apr 20)
You hesitate before pressing and. You almost put the phone down instead of making



TAURUS (Apr 20-May 20)
Some responsibilities feel heavier than load because they are new and you're still



GEMINI (May 21-June 21)
Anything "too perfect" is widely considered to be unreal. Excellence



CANCER (June 22-July 22)
Your confidence becomes contagious. People leave conversations



LEO (July 23-Aug 23)
Relationships improve, not that they seem so much as ready to become



VIRGO (Aug 24-Sept 23)
You'll encounter people who seem opposite to the things that really



LIBRA (Sept 24-Oct 23)
You focus on what people instead of keeping score of their every mistake.



SCORPIO (Oct 24-Nov 22)
Sure, you're as emotionally independent as the next person, which is to say, you're susceptible to



SAGITTARIUS (Nov 23-Dec 21)
Problems sometimes fix themselves. They can also become non-issues because people aren't used to



CAPRICORN (Dec 22-Jan 19)
In a world governed by the second law of thermodynamics, entropy is ever-present. So,



AQUARIUS (Jan 20-Feb 18)
Just when you think you know how things run, you'll discover inconsistencies, new



PISCES (Feb 19-Mar 20)
Like the parent of a tantrum-throwing toddler, in a public venue, you may momentarily concede to

YOU MIGHT BE A SENSITIVE PERSON, A SENSE OF
 AWARENESS. So, try and prove it wrong. And if you
 can't, then accept the truth. That's what will
 allow you to come up with better questions.
 The wrap-up of this Venus cycle is the oil can
 you can use to unlock what was stuck.

the call. You stand in the
 doorway for a second
 longer than necessary.
 Then you do the thing
 anyway, and the day
 changes from there.

learning or because
 you've carried them too
 long. Either way, you're
 in the ocean. You're on
 a streak now and don't
 intend to break it today.

comes with a bit of
 damage, a quirk, or
 at least a storage
 space. That's how
 people know
 it's real.

with you believing
 more is possible than
 they did on their own.
 They start making
 plans before they reach
 the parking lot.

something even more
 fitting for your life.
 Both people are ready
 to be more helpful,
 communicative,
 comfortable and fun.

matter to you. They
 won't care more just
 because they're in
 to. They'll care more
 when they finally see
 why it's important.

You aren't excusing bad
 behavior. You're making
 room for people to keep
 growing. You treat them
 with dignity and they see
 themselves as dignified.

influence. Catching vibes
 is only human. That's why
 it's crucial to surround yourself
 with people who embody
 the moods and values you
 want for yourself.

them. Real problems
 persist. They demand your
 attention until it's
 impossible to ignore them.
 If it's not really a problem,
 it fades into the scene.

perfect balance is either
 mythic or momentary. It's
 when you appreciate those
 brief moments when
 everything happens
 to line up.

routes and rollercoaster
 loops. That's why you
 no longer assume you've
 seen it all. You have a door
 open for new possibilities
 to walk through.

inconvenient and
 unreasonable demands just
 to keep the action rolling
 along without drama. But
 this will be addressed at
 a more opportune time.

Solutions to Saturday's puzzle

1	5			3	8
7	2	9		4	5
6				9	7
		3		1	8
8	2	5		3	1
		9	7	2	
5	7				4
		1	4		
	4	6		6	2
				9	3

SUDOKU EASY

TEST YOUR NUMBER CRUNCHING SKILL WITH OUR UNIQUE PUZZLE

Fill in the grid with digits in such a manner that every row, every column and every 3x3 box accommodates the digits 1 to 9, without repeating any.

7	1	3	2	6	4	8	9	
8	6	2	7	4	9	3	1	5
3	9	4	1	8	5	6	2	7
2	7	9	5	1	8	3		4
5	3	8	4	6	7	2	9	1
1	4	9	2	8	5	7	6	3
6	5	1	8	9	3	7	2	4
4	8	7	6	1	2	9	5	3
9	2	5	7	4	1	6	8	

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
9									
11			12						
14		15				16			
18								19	20
22						23			
24									

CROSS WORD

ACROSS

- Man's in a ship at sea in part of the Atlantic (7A)
- Wild boar in one African city (7)
- One may be dressed up to them - by numbers? (5)
- One shouldn't lie under it (4)
- Possibly face up to a hot drink (3,2,3)
- Times of enchantment (6)
- Play - but cheat! (6)
- Union without a single member (8)
- One covering end of chin in spots (4)
- Darkness is and isn't the same thing (5)
- Appeal in French to doctor (7)
- Is an orator lost and speechless without it? (7A)

DOWN

- The purpose of a full stop (5)
- Lighting the gas? (4)
- Uprising students make a disorder (4,2)
- Unusual gloom in a remote part of Asia (8)
- Slipshod editing made light of (7)
- Sanction to conclude or decide about personnel (11)
- Manage to avoid the final conclusion (6,5)
- Strange relics to be found in the cathedral (8)
- Angered by anagram (7)
- Consents but is a long time coming round again (6)
- Communist firm about belief (5)
- Attempt a crazy uprising (4)

SATURDAY'S SOLUTIONS

Across: 1.Pencil, 4.Awarded, 9.Said, 10.Mouth, 12.Daily, 13.Sally, 14.Party, 15.Everyone, 16.Red, 18.Land, 19.Paper, 20.Sale, 21.Held, 22.Train, 23.Target, 24.Correct, 25.Spect.

Down: 1.Present, 2.Reused, 3.Risk, 5.Shoulder, 6.Ache, 7.Torture, 8.Bella, 9.Fiber, 10.Chair, 11.Slack, 12.Bag, 13.Bag, 14.Bag, 15.Bag, 16.Bag, 17.Bag, 18.Bag, 19.Bag, 20.Bag, 21.Bag.

JUMBLE

BY DAVID L. HOYT AND JEFF KNUREX

UNSCRAMBLE THESE JUMBLES, ONE LETTER TO EACH SQUARE, TO FORM FOUR ORDINARY WORDS.

NHUKC
 OTBOH
 AFLWE
 DLLOBY

Answers: (horizontal) GUIDE, CLASH, PARADE, GLADLY. (vertical) When his girlfriend broke up with him on Friday, the weekend started on a - "SADDER-DAY".

Why 'route thala' culture continues to fuel student violence in Chennai

Experts say police action won't suffice, suggest revival of union polls, counselling & guidance

BINITA JAISWAL & GAUTHAM SELVARAJAN @ Chennai

A week ago, 18-year-old Nithesh Kumar and a 17-year-old boy were attacked with knives allegedly by a group of armed college students inside the subway connecting Chennai Central metro and the suburban railway station. The attack, police said, was the latest chapter in a long-standing rivalry between students commuting on the Gummidipoondi and Tiruttani railway routes. The July 27 incident led to the arrest of eight students on charges of attempted murder.



'Route thala' revolves around students asserting dominance over the bus or suburban train routes they use to commute between home and college | FILE PIC

It was the third such clash reported in the city in just over two weeks. Earlier three students were arrested after a clash at Guindy railway station on July 20, while a Presidency College student was attacked by another student on July 8.

'Route thala'

Police officers investigating such cases said they all trace back to 'route thala', a phenomenon considered unique to Chennai. It revolves around students asserting dominance over the bus or suburban train routes they use to commute between home and college. A Government Railway Police (GRP) officer who investigated the 2024 murder of a 28-year-old Presidency College student, allegedly at the hands of Pachaiyappa's College students, said the motive behind such attacks is often impossible to pin down.

The rivalry has persisted for decades, passed down from one batch of students to the next. "It's like peeling an onion. Almost none of these cases have a clear motive. They result from students trying to assert domi-

nance over others on the routes they travel between home and college," another officer said. "During our inquiry, we found that many current students consider it their duty to carry forward the tradition."

The clashes are predominantly associated with students of Pachaiyappa's College, Presidency College and Government Arts College, Nandanam, although students from a few other institutions are occasionally involved, the officer said. Police said they have repeatedly written to the colleges concerned and run awareness programmes involving parents, but with limited success. "In most cases, the parents of the accused are daily wage labourers and are unaware of their children's activities outside their homes," the officer said.

A senior police officer said colleges should identify vulnerable students early, and encourage them to participate in academics and extracurricular activities before rivalries set in. "At the same time, visible policing at railway stations and bus

stops during peak college hours can help prevent clashes before they escalate," he said.

Pattern of violence

Experts argue that the problem reflects deeper social and institutional issues. Every year, they say, the pattern repeats itself: a violent clash, hospitalised students, arrests, tightened campus security and then the violence shifts to buses, railway stations and arterial roads where colleges have little control.

"What happens inside the campus is completely different from what happens outside," said Baby Gulnaz, principal of Pachaiyappa's College. She said strict monitoring has ensured such incidents are rare on campus, but regulating students once they leave college is nearly impossible. The college now plans counselling and awareness sessions with senior police officers to highlight how a single act of violence can derail a student's education and career.

"If students do not attend classes regularly, disciplining or reforming them becomes diffi-

cult," she noted.

Search for an identity

Former principals and alumni believe the absence of student union elections has also removed a constructive outlet for leadership and competition.

Sam Gabriel, a Pachaiyappa's alumnus pursuing PG at JNU, said many students come from economically disadvantaged backgrounds, broken families or neighbourhoods where violence is normalised. "Teachers must help students recognise their worth and show them a career path. Instead, many feel labelled as failures from the day they enter college," he added.

Psychiatrist Dr Lakshmi Vijayakumar stressed on the film industry's habit of glorifying aggression through hyper-masculine heroes, which, combined with peer pressure, can push young people towards imitating reckless behaviour. "When students move in groups, individual accountability weakens and mob mentality takes over," she said. Experts said reviving student elections, strengthening mentorship, expanding sports and cultural activities, regular counselling, early identification of vulnerable students and firm action against habitual offenders must all happen together to end this cycle of violence.

As former University of Madras vice-chancellor SP Thyagarajan put it, 'route thala' is "not merely a law-and-order issue. It reflects a crisis of identity among a section of young people searching for recognition. Unless colleges, families, police and society offer students a more meaningful sense of belonging and purpose, we may continue to witness the same cycle of violence and crackdowns."



Tibetans from across South India gathered at Besant Nagar Beach on Sunday to stage a silent protest against China's repression of Tibetans | MARTIN LOUIS

EXPRESS READ

₹1 crore in unaccounted cash seized from van

CHENNAI: Three people, including two from Andhra Pradesh, were caught for carrying ₹1 crore in a courier van without valid documents. During an inspection at Padiyannur checkpoint near Senguppuram on Saturday, police found the cash concealed in three bags. Suspects told the police that they had come to Chennai to buy gold Jewels from Sowcarpet. They were let go, but as they could not furnish valid documents, the cash was handed over to I-T department. ENS

Fish vendor dies as mini lorry rams bike

CHENNAI: A 34-year-old fish vendor was killed after a mini lorry ramed his two-wheeler on GST Road early Saturday morning. Vigneshwaran of New Perungalathur was riding to Padappai in Kanchipuram district when the mini lorry, travelling towards Chrompet, allegedly hit his bike near the Pallavaram signal. The impact of the crash threw him off the vehicle and led to severe head injuries. Lorry driver Ravikumar (54) has been arrested and further investigation is on. ENS

Trader dies after parked auto rolls into canal

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Chennai

A 56-year-old mattress trader from Chennai died after his autorickshaw rolled into a canal near Puthur on Saturday. The deceased was identified as Murugesan, a resident of Surapur near Puthur. According to the Pennalurpet police, he had travelled to villages in Tiruvallur along with Suman (44) to sell mattresses. After completing their sales at Ponthavakkam, the duo stopped near the canal. While Suman was taking a bath in a nearby field, Murugesan attempted to reposition the parked auto. Police said the vehicle rolled forward, plunged into the canal and dragged Murugesan underwater. Residents who witnessed the incident alerted the Pennalurpet police, who, with the help of the Fire and Rescue Services personnel, retrieved the submerged auto and recovered the body.

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Stalin and DKS nexus undermining state's interest in Cauvery dispute: Nirmal Kumar

Minister claims Karunanidhi had pressured K'taka not to release water to TN when Jayalalithaa was chief minister

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Chennai

ELECTRICITY and Law Minister CTR Nirmal Kumar on Sunday alleged there existed a close nexus between DMK president MK Stalin and Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, and claimed that it was undermining Tamil Nadu's interests in the Cauvery water dispute.

He also defended the state government's decision not to convene an all-party meeting to discuss the next course of action, arguing that political parties in Tamil Nadu held divergent views on the issue, unlike their counterparts in Karnataka.

Answering queries by reporters at the Chennai airport, the minister said, "Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar (DKS) and the DMK's first family have shared a close relationship that goes beyond party politics, for many years. Whatever DKS wishes, the DMK will echo and vice versa."

The minister added that it was widely claimed that DKS was more eager than anyone else to see DMK return to power. "Many have further alleged that, rather than listening to the Congress leadership, DKS pays greater heed to what MK Stalin says. What has happened over the past week has reflected that," Nirmal Kumar added.

The minister alleged that, during the tenure of former chief minister J Jayalalithaa, then DMK president M Karunanidhi exerted pressure on Karnataka not to release Cauvery water because doing so would earn her political credit. He further alleged that DMK was pursuing the same approach even today.

Referring to Stalin's remark that Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay had become "isolated", the minister said it appeared to have been made with the intention of causing a setback to the people of Tamil Nadu on the Cauvery water dispute.

The minister recalled that on Saturday, the CM had held consultations with legal experts and decided to move the Supreme Court and completed the necessary legal consultations and preparations for filing the petition. However, while that process was under way, the DMK hurriedly filed its own petition after 5 pm, he alleged.

Nirmal Kumar said filing multiple petitions on behalf of the same state would create confusion and weaken Tamil Nadu's legal position.

The minister said former CM Jayalalithaa had taken firm stance to safeguard Tamil Nadu's interests on the Cauvery issue, whereas now, AIADMK was acting in support of Karnataka and BJP by toying their line.

With regard to the reported release of 12,000 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu from the Kabinri reservoir, the minister said it is not enough for the state. "We need to get 15 TMC water from Karnataka," he said and recalled that CWMa on Thursday upheld the CWRC recommendation ordering the release of 3,500 cusecs daily to Tamil Nadu for the next 15 days.

KV Elankkaran, president of the federation, who led the delegation, said the police forcibly put them on the Tamil Nadu Express despite repeated requests to allow them to continue their journey. The farmers have planned to stage a demonstration in front of the Union Jal Shakti Ministry office on August 4.

Condemning the arrest of Tamil Nadu farmers by Maharashtra police, DMK youth wing secretary Udhayanidhi Stalin, on Sunday, said CM C Joseph Vijay should take immediate steps to secure the release of the farmers and seek an explanation from the Maharashtra government for their arrest.

Meanwhile, PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss, in his message, said, "Stopping them and forcing them off the train is a violation of their human rights and an attack on Tamil Nadu's rights." The Tamil Nadu Farmers' Association (CPM) urged the centre to immediately release the farmers arrested for exercising their democratic right to protest and to make the necessary arrangements for them to proceed to Delhi.

Many have alleged that, rather than listening to the Congress leadership, DKS pays greater heed to what MK Stalin says. What has happened over the past week has reflected that

Nirmal Kumar, minister of electricity and law

Paranatham said all previous CMs of Tamil Nadu had convened all-party meetings before taking major decisions on the Cauvery issue. Referring to Nirmal Kumar's remark that an all-party meeting could not be convened in the absence of consensus, he said differences of opinion among political parties were natural.

"It is the CM's responsibility to bring all political parties together and build a consensus," he said. The DMK leader also questioned why neither the CM, the water resources minister, nor the department secretary disclosed the outcome of the Saturday's meeting on the Cauvery issue. Responding to Nirmal Kumar's claim that

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar did not pay heed to the views of the Congress leadership on the Cauvery issue, Paranatham said the minister should reveal what Congress leader Rahul Gandhi had conveyed to Shivakumar and what advice he had allegedly refused.

Meanwhile, former law minister S Regupathy, in a statement, urged the TN government to immediately convene an all-party meeting. He said Nirmal Kumar should express regret for his "irresponsible" remarks against Karunanidhi.

Tiruppur MP K Subbarayan added, "It is not acceptable for a responsible minister to level such allegations without proper evidence."

TN farmers made to deboard train forcibly at Nagpur by Maha police

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Chennai

THE members of the Federation of Cauvery Delta Irrigation Farmers' Associations, who were travelling by train to stage a demonstration in New Delhi demanding immediate release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu, were forced to alight at Nagpur by the Maharashtra police on Sunday and were sent back to Tamil Nadu against their will.

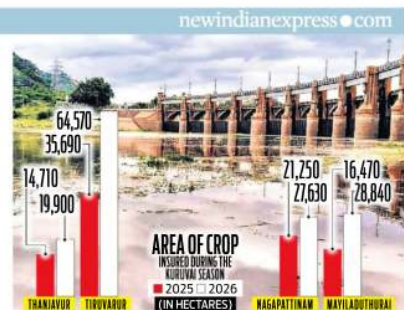
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CONDOLES DEATH

CM C Joseph Vijay on Sunday condoled the death of KMK Kaleelur Rahman, elder son of IUML national president KM Kader Mohideen, following an illness. Vijay conveyed his deepest condolences to the bereaved family, his relatives and friends



Mettur water delay pushes crop insurance coverage in delta dists

N RAMESH @ Thanjavur

THE crop insurance coverage during the Kuruvaai season in the four Cauvery delta districts of Thanjavur, Tiruvavur, Nagapattinam and Mayiladuthurai increased this year compared to last year as there is uncertainty of water release from Mettur Dam and apprehension of crop failure. The awareness created among the farmers about the compensation for the prevented sowing clause is also cited as another reason.

As the water was not released from Mettur dam on the stipulated date of June 12, only those farmers who got agriculture electricity connections cultivated Kuruvaai paddy this year using the ground water. Hence the total area under Kuruvaai paddy cultivation in the four districts has come down from 1.86 lakh hectares in 2025 to 1.37 lakh hectares in 2026. However the crop insurance coverage of Kuruvaai crop has increased this year compared to last year.

During the 2025 Kuruvaai season a total of 88,130 hectares was covered under the crop insurance in the four districts of Thanjavur, Tiruvavur, Mayiladuthurai and Nagapattinam. However this year the crop insurance coverage increased to

1.41 lakh hectares. Of the four districts, Tiruvavur saw a steep increase from 35,690 hectares in 2025 to 64,570 hectares this year.

P S Masilamani, a farmer from Tiruvavur district and the state general secretary of TN farmers association said, "As there is uncertainty over when the water from Mettur will be released, the farmers who used to supplement ground water with canal water are apprehensive of saving the Kuruvaai crop. Moreover the farmers are expecting compensation under the prevented sowing clause. Hence the increase in the insurance coverage."

P Sukumaran of Tiruvaiyaru in Thanjavur district says, "I always pay a premium for Kuruvaai crop. This year I prepared for Kuruvaai cultivation, but due to non-availability of water, I could not sow. I am expecting compensation under the prevented sowing clause," he added.

Agriculture and farmers welfare department officials point out the awareness drive taken up by the department along with insurance companies on prevented sowing clause has been one of the reasons for the increase in the coverage this year.

DMK accuses TVK govt of lack of transparency

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Chennai

TAKING strong exception to Electricity and Law Minister C T R Nirmal Kumar's criticism of former chief minister M Karunanidhi over the Cauvery water dispute, DMK advocates wing joint secretary I Paranatham on Sunday accused the TVK government of lacking transparency in handling the issue. He also questioned the transfer of the water resources secretary at a time when the Cauvery dispute was at a critical stage.

Paranatham demanded that the government answer three questions within 24 hours: what are the steps taken to constitute a tribunal to adjudicate the Mekedatu dam dispute, as



I Paranatham addressing a press meet at the DMK headquarters | EXPRESS

resolved by the Tamil Nadu Assembly; what were the decisions taken at the meeting chaired by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Saturday regarding the Cauvery issue; and what were the reasons for the lack of an official announcement about the CM's proposed visit to Karnataka.

Addressing a press confer-

ence at the DMK headquarters, Paranatham said all previous CMs of Tamil Nadu had convened all-party meetings before taking major decisions on the Cauvery issue. Referring to Nirmal Kumar's remark that an all-party meeting could not be convened in the absence of consensus, he said differences of opinion among political parties were natural.

"It is the CM's responsibility to bring all political parties together and build a consensus," he said. The DMK leader also questioned why neither the CM, the water resources minister, nor the department secretary disclosed the outcome of the Saturday's meeting on the Cauvery issue. Responding to Nirmal Kumar's claim that

TN eyes ₹50K-cr investment fund, AI City, automated welfare in vision plan

PRABHAKAR TAMILARASU
@ Chennai

THE TVK-led government's Vetri Thamizhagam Vision pitches for a ₹50,000-crore state investment fund to invest in emerging sectors, building a first-of-its-kind AI City, rolling out a "no-application" welfare delivery system and guaranteeing time-bound government services under a Right to Service Act, among others, over the next five years.

Furthermore, the vision document proposes a "People's Choice Budget", a participatory initiative where citizens directly decide how 10% of district-level development funds are utilised.

TNIE has exclusively accessed the Vetri Thamizhagam Vision, prepared by the state government's Special Programme Implementation Department, which was discussed in the new government's first cabinet meeting with 436 proposals across 35 departments for the next five years.

The state has proposed to set up Tamil Nadu Strategic Investment Authority (TNSIA) with a ₹50,000-crore corpus, from which the government will directly invest in high-growth sectors such as semiconductors, electric vehicles (EVs), aerospace, artificial intelligence (AI), and advanced manufacturing.

"Rather than merely facilitating private investments, the Tamil Nadu government will co-invest alongside industries, create new economic value, and



Five-year vision

- To set up Tamil Nadu Strategic Investment Authority with a corpus of ₹50,000 crore
- No-application governance model – Deliver welfare scheme benefits to citizens without requiring them to file an application at all
- People's choice budget – Citizens directly decide how 10% of district-level devt funds are utilised

share ownership in these ventures. This approach will generate lakhs of high-quality jobs while also creating new non-tax revenue streams for the state," the vision document read.

The document has also proposed a pioneering fiscal reporting system called "First Five Special Budgets". The social justice budget statement focuses on the advancement of Adi Dravidar, tribal, and marginalised communities. The balanced regional development budget statement addresses the 3:1 income disparity between developed and backward regions by targeting 12 underdeveloped districts.

The Tamil Nadu cultural and heritage budget statement is dedicated to protecting archaeological sites like Keeladi and promoting Tamil culture globally. The education and healthcare equity budget statement aims at reduc-

ing quality disparities between urban and rural facilities. Finally, the environmental budget statement prioritises marine conservation, flood management, and climate resilience.

Through the "Chief Minister's People Service Friends", the vision also proposed a "no-application" governance model, to make Tamil Nadu the first state in the country to deliver welfare scheme benefits to eligible citizens without requiring them to file an application at all.

"Using digital data integrated from Aadhaar, ration cards, family records, and service databases, eligible beneficiaries will be automatically identified through technology-driven systems," the document read.

Through the "Chief Minister's People Service Friends" initiative, welfare benefits will be delivered directly to beneficiaries

on their doorstep, it added.

The document also commits to a full-scale AI push. This includes Arivagam, pitched as India's first dedicated AI City, which would house an AI university, a high-performance GPU (graphics processing unit) compute cluster, semiconductor testing labs, and international skill centres.

Speaking to TNIE, a minister said that of the total 436 proposals, some are being implemented including the Vetri Tamil Nadu Super App. "Through the Super App, citizens can access 500 government services, including birth certificates, ration cards and driving licence renewals, from their mobile phones. This is already in the process and it would soon be implemented," the minister said.

Among student welfare schemes, the government pushes to establish the Periyar Institute of Emerging Technologies to offer specialised courses in AI, quantum computing, biotechnology, climate technology, space technology, and cybersecurity.

For students willing to pursue higher education and living expenses for students admitted to the world's top 100 universities, in return for a three-year service commitment in Tamil Nadu.

Similarly, in order to extend the work-from-hometown model, the government pitches for micro-technology parks and co-working hubs across the state.

3 years on, MSMEs await relief from repeated regn of title deed deposit

S KUMARESAN @ Chennai

loan amount or the property offered as security.

Under the present system, MSMEs creating an equitable mortgage to obtain bank loans must register MoDT. Entrepreneurs said borrowers are charged 0.6% of the loan amount for loans up to ₹80 lakh, while loans above ₹80 lakh attract a flat fee of ₹48,000. They have urged the government to introduce two or three slabs and cap the maximum charge at ₹25,000.

Tamil Nadu Small and Tiny Industries Association (TANSITIA) president S Vasudevan told TNIE the association has repeatedly raised the issue with the government since the announcement made during the 'Thol Kodupom Thozhilukku' MSME conference in Madurai in September 2022.

He said TANSITIA had also sought clarification from RBI, which informed the association it has not prescribed annual renewal of MoDT. The association has now submitted another representation to the state registration minister seeking immediate implementation of the announcement.



SPIRITUAL TRANCE

Devotees perform ritualistic dances during the sacred Tamil month of Aadi at Arulmiga Muthumariamman Aalayam at Kilpaik on Sunday | P JANARDHAN

SDAT to hire expert team to manage TN sporting events

CHENNAI: The Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT) has decided to create a project management unit (PMU) by appointing experts to conduct various sporting events, including the Chief Minister's Trophy, and also attract CSR funds to help the authority create infrastructure.

According to the request for proposal (RFP) document, the PMU will conduct a gap analysis of the vision document by comparing it with national and global policies. It will also develop policies including duties, roles and responsibilities and benefits for all the stakeholders and user groups.

The unit will assist in legacy planning and livelihood development to promote sports as a career and in preparing talent identification strategy and plan in consultation with all the stakeholders and user groups.

The unit will also assist SDAT in collaborating with international partners for conducting camps and promoting corporate participation. ENS

EXPRESS READ

TNPDCCL sets new wind power evacuation record

Chennai: The Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDCCL) on Saturday set a new record by evacuating 142.43 million units (MU) of wind power, surpassing its previous highest evacuation of 139.93 MU recorded just three days earlier on Wednesday (July 29). Since the start of the current wind season in May, the discom has crossed the 100-MU wind power evacuation mark 26 times, the highest ever recorded in the state. During the previous wind season, it crossed the 100-MU mark only 12 times. The sharp rise in wind power generation comes as the southwest monsoon has strengthened across TN, resulting in higher wind speeds in major wind power regions. ENS

Two TVK functionaries held for cheating man of ₹22L

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
@ Virudhunagar

TWO TVK functionaries in Arupukottai town were arrested by the district crime branch police on Saturday for allegedly cheating a transport operator of ₹21.99 lakh.

The two party functionaries

allegedly used the name of Prohibition and Excise Minister K Vignesh and promised to secure the transporter a Tasmac loading contract.

Those arrested are Karthikeyan (30) and Satheshees Kumar (28), both Arupukottai Town secretaries of the party. Their associate Prashanth Uthaman

(42) of Coimbatore, who is also an accused, is absconding.

They were arrested following a complaint by Soundarajan, a transport operator based in Arupukottai.

Last month, he was allegedly approached by the accused trio, allegedly assuring him that they could secure a contract for

transporting liquor consignments from Tasmac warehouses to retail outlets in the district. Believing their assurance, Soundarajan allegedly paid the accused ₹21.99 lakh last month.

However, the promised contract was never secured and the money was not returned.



05 CHENNAI

TAMIL NADU/SOUTH

YOUTH HELD

A day after Sathish Kumar (33) was allegedly hacked to death near Pothur, the Avadi Tank Factory police on Sunday arrested B Bharath (20). The suspect allegedly told the police that he carried out the murder over previous enmity

newindianexpress.com

Will protect interests of K'taka, its people: DKS

While urging parties to drop bandh plan on Aug 13, CM reiterates Mekedatu dam long-term solution to Cauvery dispute

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
@ Bengaluru

CHIEF Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday said protecting the interests of the state and its people will remain the government's highest priority as it deals with the Cauvery water-sharing dispute. He appealed to political parties and Kannada organisations not to go ahead with a bandh, called on August 13, over the issue.

Addressing reporters after an all-party meeting on the Cauvery issue, Shivakumar asserted that the interests and welfare of Karnataka's people are paramount and that neither he nor his government will do anything to harm the state's interests. He said Karnataka is witnessing a severe rainfall deficit and appealed to farmers to remain patient till the government issues district-specific guidance on cultivation.

Shivakumar reiterated that



Chief Minister D K Shivakumar with former CM Siddaramaiah and BJP leader B S Yeddyurappa during the all-party meet on Cauvery issue in Bengaluru | EXPRESS

Nearly 90% of Mekedatu project's benefits would accrue to TN. It will regulate flow rather than divert water to Bengaluru

D K Shivakumar, Karnataka CM

the proposed Mekedatu balancing water reservoir will be a long-term solution to the Cauvery dispute.

He claimed that nearly 90 per cent of the project's benefits would accrue to Tamil Nadu,

arguing that the reservoir will regulate water flows rather than divert water to Bengaluru.

Shivakumar also said Karnataka will continue to abide by the Supreme Court's directions

and statutory orders despite the severe rainfall deficit. Karnataka has received only around 35% of its normal rainfall so far this year.

But inflows into reservoirs have improved in recent days with nearly 24,000 cusecs entering the reservoirs. But the rainfall has reduced slightly since Saturday afternoon, while the

Kabini reservoir is receiving around 11,000 cusecs of inflows.

Referring to the Cauvery Water Management Authority's directive to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days, the chief minister said the state was complying with the order while safeguarding its legal interests.

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
@ Palakkad

A 40-year-old woman from Tamil Nadu died after she lost her footing and fell to the bottom of the Palakuzhy waterfalls near Kizhakkenchery.

around 50 km from Palakkad —on Sunday afternoon, even as the authorities are investigating how a tourist group entered the area despite a ban on visits to waterfalls and hilly destinations amid heavy monsoon rain in the district.

The deceased has been identified as Bhanupriya, wife of Sivakumar who works in IT sector in Bengaluru. According to the Vadakkenchery police, she was part of a five-member group that visited the waterfalls around noon.

The accident occurred around 12:30 pm when Bhanupriya slipped from the second tier of the waterfall and plunged into the gorge about 200 feet below.

Personnel from the fire and

rescue services recovered her body after a difficult operation. Another member of the group, Bharath, who attempted to rescue Bhanupriya, also fell into the water. He was rescued by a sensational Rope Rescue Team.

The police said the five persons involved — three women and two men — are neighbours residing near the Tamil Church at Viswasapuram near Saravanampatti in Coimbatore.

11 dead in Kerala rain

Though Kerala had a respite from heavy rain for most of Sunday, floodwaters are yet to recede completely in several parts of the state. As many as 11 people have lost their lives so far, and a total of 30 houses have been destroyed and 293 partially damaged in the landslides. Around 273 relief camps are operational in the state, sheltering 7,674 people. Meanwhile, the IMD has issued a yellow alert for all districts on Monday, and isolated heavy showers are expected across the state on the day.

FLOOD ALERT ISSUED ALONG BHAVANI RIVER AS PILLUR DAM RELEASES SURPLUS WATER

COIMBATORE: A flood alert was issued along the Bhavani River on Sunday after the Pillur dam reached its full storage capacity following heavy rainfall in the Nilgiris, prompting officials to release surplus water. Authorities have urged residents living along the river banks in Mettupalayam and downstream areas to remain vigilant and move to safer locations if necessary. As a precautionary measure, the public has also been prohibited from

Seven cops in Tiruppur facing graft charges shunted to Armed Reserve

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
@ Tiruppur

SEVEN policemen at-

In the incident, three people, including a woman, died while five others sustained injuries. They

information that some police personnel were not properly maintaining station records and lacked administrative compe-

Three injured in cylinder blast die in Thanjai govt hosp

THANJAVUR: Three people who were injured in an LPG cylinder blast last week near Tiruvonam, succumbed at the Government Thanjavur Medical College

Akash was rushed to a nearby private hospital, where he died during treatment. The police have registered a case and are probing the circumstances surrounding the death. They are also examining the alleged assault, the suspected financial misappropriation, and the involvement of those connected to both the attack and the missing funds. **ENS**

CHENNAI: VASCCO, a Pudukcherry-based travel, tourism, lifestyle and business networking organisation, hosted the 15th edition of BuildCon 2026 at Hotel Pullman on July 31, bringing together builders, architects, real estate developers, and industry experts to discuss developments in the construction and real estate sectors. The event also marked the launch of the Chennai chapter of the Busihunt Business Club, a business networking platform. **ENS**

It is alleged that some police personnel demanded money to complete formalities, including handing over the matter to the relatives of the victims.

Based on an inquiry, SP Shrishti Singh ordered the transfer of four head constables and three Grade-I constables attached to the Uthukuli police station to the Armed Forces Police on Sunday.

Ten people suffered injuries when a LPG cylinder exploded while they were trying to put out a fire in a house at Chinna Ammankudi in the wee hours of July 30. ENS

Figure 1. Supply and demand curves.

CHENNAI: Around 500 healthcare professionals and students participated in a walkathon organised by the Neonatology Association of Tamil Nadu (NATN), and the Rotary Club of Chennai Kilpauk, at Besant Nagar beach on Sunday to promote awareness about breastfeeding, as part of World Breastfeeding Week 2026. The campaign stressed on the need to strengthen human milk banks and promote donation to improve the survival of sick and preterm newborns. ENS

the consequences of drug use and briefed students about the various scopes and opportunities available for higher education. Around 2,500 students and 250 staff of Amrita Vidyalayam participated in the launch online and took a pledge against drugs. The school had also organised a series of awareness programmes, including a quiz competition, drawing competition, expert talk, and an awareness walkathon in the last two weeks.

Chennai: Joining hands against drugs, Amrita Vidyalayam, located at Nesapakkam near KK Nagar, on Sunday organised a live stream of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's launch of Nasha Mukta Yuva Sankalp Abhiyan - a 100-week nationwide anti-drug campaign. Dr S R Niranjan, academician and guest of honour at the programme, talked about the students about the various scopes and action. Around 2,500 students and 250 staff of the school online and took a pledge against the series of awareness programmes, including a expert talk, and an awareness walkathon in the school campus.

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Corrigendum No. 21 (Time Extension) Dated: 01/08/2026
ender No. 01/DGM (E&M D-I)/UJVN/2025-26

Unavoidable reasons, the dates of e-Tender No. 01/DGM(E&M D-I)/UJVN/2025-26 invited by office of the Dy. General Manager, E&M D-I, UJVN Ltd., Gangra Bhawan, Yamuna Colony, Dehradun (Uttaranchal) are as under:-

For submission of bid in e-portals : 13.08.2026 up to 17.00 Hrs.

For submission of Original document (Hard copies) : 18.08.2026 up to 17.00 Hrs.

ies are available at: May I request resolution applicants under Section 252(3)(b) of the Code is available at: date for receipt of expression of interest date of issue of provisional list of prospective resolution applicants date for submission of objections to (provisional) list date of issue of final list of prospective resolution applicants date of issue of information memorandum, valuation matrix and request for resolution to prospective resolution applicants date for submission of resolution plans date and email to submit EOI details of the corporate debtor's resolution status as ISME	Can be sought by sending a request to RP at: RP at: corp.positivehourings@gmail.com 13.08.2020 25.08.2020 31.08.2020 07.09.2020 08.09.2020 09.10.2020 09.10.2020 corp.positivehourings@gmail.com NA
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August 2026
 (signature)

Sd/-
Ranjana Singh -representing
Boyer Resolutions Private Limited (PR)
Resolution Professional of

QuoteExpress

TRY TO BE A RAINBOW !

● ● ● ● ●

THE NEW INDIAN EXPRESS

FORM G	
INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR POSITIVE HOUSINGS PRIVATE LIMITED ENGAGED IN REAL ESTATE BUSINESS (Under Regulation 34A(1) of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)	
RELEVANT PARTICULARS	
1. Name of the corporate debtor and CIN	POSITIVE HOUSINGS PRIVATE LIMITED (CIN: U70101TN2005PT131430)
2. Address of the registered office	New No.63, GH Chetty Road, T Nagar, Chennai - 600017 Tamil Nadu, NA
3. URL of website	NA
4. Details of places where the majority of fixed assets are located	Malayore, Chennai.
5. The installed capacity of main products (Annual Production Capacity in Metric Tons)	NA
6. Quantity and value of main products/ services sold in the last financial year	NA
7. Number of employees/ workmen	NA
8. Further details including the last available financial statements, lists of creditors, and relevant dates for subsequent events of the process are available at:	Can be sought by sending a request to Resolution Professional at: corp.positivehousing@gmail.com
9. Eligibility for resolution applicants under section 25(2)(b) of the Code is available at:	Can be sought by sending a request to RP at: corp.positivehousing@gmail.com
10. Last date for receipt of expression of interest	13.08.2026
11. Date of issue of provisional list of prospective resolution applicants	25.08.2026
12. Last date for submission of objections to provisional list	31.08.2026
13. Date of issue of final list of prospective resolution applicants	07.09.2026
14. Date of issue of information memorandum, evaluation matrix and request for resolution plans to prospective resolution applicants	08.09.2026
15. Last date for submission of resolution plans	08.10.2026
16. Process email to be sent to EOI	corp.positivehousing@gmail.com
17. Details of the corporate debtor's registration status as MSME	NA

Sd/-
Ranjana Singh - representing
Beiyler Resolutions Private Limited (BCLR)
 Resolution Professional of
 Positive Housing Private Limited
 Address: Shreevictas, 428, 19th B Cross,
 3rd Block, Jayanagar, Bengaluru - 560011
 Tel: 080 4312 4113; Phone : 991 94481 46963
 Email: corp.positivehousing@gmail.com

Date: 1st August 2026
 Place: Bengaluru

The life of the law has not been logic; it has been experience

The rise in girl-child adoptions comes as overall adoptions have also increased. For the first time in more than a decade, India crossed the 5,000 mark in a year. Data shared by the Central Adoption Resource Authority (CARA) shows that 5,022 children were adopted in 2005-06, including 4,695 through

While ruling leaders describe the changes as a structural measure needed to clear severe case backlogs and modernise public institutions, legal scholars, civil society groups and independent observers widely view the sudden timing as a move designed to influence judicial leadership succession.

From crowded prisons to overburdened courtrooms, the nation's crises continue to unfold across multiple fronts, rendering the debate over judicial retirement ages a pivotal flash-

DILRUKSHI HANUNDNETTI

Award-winning journalist and lawyer; founder and director of Colombo-based Center for Investigative Reporting



While opponents maintain that these bottlenecks cannot be resolved simply by postponing retirements without addressing deeper procedural flaws, the government insists that term extensions are just one part of the NPP's broader reform package. Ministry officials point to ongoing efforts to expand court administrative staff, reorganise

domestic adoption and 337 through inter-country adoption. This was higher than the 4,515 adoptions recorded in 2024-25.

The increase, however, also highlights the challenges within the adoption system. Nearly 26,000 prospective adoptive parents are registered with CARA. However, parents wanting to adopt a child below two years wait three and a half years. The central challenge is the pace at which children who cannot be reunited with their biological families are declared legally free for adoption and matched with waiting parents. Protecting the rights of biological families is essential, but avoidable administrative delays postpone a child's opportunity to grow up in a permanent home.

Equally noteworthy is the 25 percent increase in the adoption of children with special needs. These children have traditionally faced greater barriers in finding permanent families. The trend suggests that more families are willing to look beyond age, gender and disability while adopting a child. If sustained, this could become one of the most meaningful changes in India's adoption landscape.

Greater transparency from CARA, including state-wise details on waiting periods, children declared legally free for adoption and adoption outcomes, would help policymakers distinguish social change from administrative progress and design better reforms. The record of 5,022 adoptions is, therefore, not just an administrative achievement. It points to an India that is becoming more open to adoption, more accepting of daughters and more willing to embrace children with special needs. Public policy must now keep pace by ensuring that every child who needs a family finds one without unnecessary delay.

HYDRAA MUST MATCH INTENT WITH INTEGRITY

HYDRAA or the Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency set up by Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy to protect government lands and lakes from encroachments, has run into rough weather: The Telangana High Court, hearing a petition by a builder, first ordered deployment of Army personnel to protect a disputed land parcel from HYDRAA, though it later kept that order in abeyance. It then directed the state government to replace HYDRAA chief A V Ranganath, citing contempt of court and 63 pending cases against the agency. The developments raise important questions.

HYDRAA says it acted on complaints from the Society to Save Rocks and that the builder had misled the court because the land where it acted was three kilometres away from the petitioner's site. Whatever the competing claims, the court concluded that its orders had been violated. Under the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971, contempt can attract imprisonment, a fine or both, and the court may or may not accept an apology. If the court found repeated violations of its orders, it may have had grounds to hold the HYDRAA chief guilty of contempt and even direct his removal in what it viewed as exceptional circumstances. But the earlier order seeking Army deployment appeared excessive and invited criticism as judicial overreach.

The episode risks damaging public confidence in both the judiciary and HYDRAA, with competing narratives already circulating on social media. Since its creation, HYDRAA has attracted controversy. Yet it has also claimed success in protecting lakes and recovering government land said to be worth about ₹1.5 lakh crore. Its critics, including the Opposition Bharat Rashtra Samithi, argue that it has acted selectively, targeting smaller encroachments while sparing influential violators. Some of those concerns cannot be dismissed lightly.

Even so, the need for an agency like HYDRAA is indisputable. Encroachments on government land and water bodies in and around Hyderabad have reached a scale that demands a dedicated enforcement mechanism. The answer is not to weaken such an institution but to make it more transparent and accountable. The government should complete scientific mapping of government land, lakes, parks and other protected areas, place the information in the public domain, and fix responsibility on officials who approved illegal construction. The first step, though, is to make sure that the executive and judiciary do not lock horns.

QUICK TAKE

THE COOLING TRAP

EUROPE'S record-breaking heat is changing old habits. Air conditioning, long dismissed as an unnecessary luxury, is becoming a necessity as temperatures cross 38°C and heat-related deaths run into the thousands. Sales are rising fast, with industry association Eurostat projecting that the EU will have over 100 million household ACs by 2030. Here's the paradox: Together, those machines could emit 15-20 million tonnes of CO₂ annually and, unless powered by clean electricity, add to the emissions warming the planet. The heat creates a need for cooling, and the cooling risks adding to the heat. But once societies become used to air-conditioned comfort, will they ever be willing—or even able—to give it up?

point regarding the future of constitutional democracy and democratic governance in Sri Lanka.

The policy initiative was pushed through a cabinet paper last week by Justice and National Integration Minister Harshana Nanayakkara. If enacted by parliament, statutory retirement limits would expand across the bench by two years: Supreme Court justices would serve until age 67 rather than 65; Court of Appeal judges would remain on the bench until 65; High Court judges would retire at 63; and lower-tier magistrates alongside district court judges would retire at 62. Proponents within the administration maintain that prolonged terms will preserve institutional expertise, curb professional brain drain, expand administrative capacity and operationalise key campaign commitments of the National People's Power (NPP) aimed at building a modern, efficient and transparent justice framework that could guarantee the delivery of justice at speed.

Despite these formal justifications, the abrupt submission of the cabinet paper has triggered immediate scepticism and public criticism regarding the governing NPP coalition's motives.

Detractors argue that utilising a commanding parliamentary supermajority to adjust sitting limits mid-service



SOURAV KOY

strikes at the heart of institutional independence and destabilises constitutional safeguards. In particular, critics allege that the primary impetus behind the legislative push is to prolong the tenure of the incumbent chief justice while quickly blocking the advancement of the bench's next senior Supreme Court judge from being elevated to the top position. This perception of political expediency sparked public debate, with the legal fraternity convening a historic general meeting of the Bar Association of Sri Lanka (BASL) on July 29, drawing unprecedentedly high attendance via physical and virtual channels. More significant than the numbers is the unanimous adoption of a resolution opposing mid-service tenure alterations.

The legislative drive has also exposed internal discord within the government's

own base of support. Key legal figures affiliated with the ruling party, such as senior practitioner Lal Wijeyanake, publicly broke ranks with the administration line during the BASL assembly, revealing that the party's primary decision-making bodies had never requested the extension scheme. This internal friction was further corroborated by senior party insiders who noted off the record that global benchmarks were being retroactively cited to justify a measure that was never part of the original legal overhaul envisioned by the administration. Furthermore, representative bodies such as the Judicial Service Association of Sri Lanka, which represents district judges and magistrates, warned of severe administrative ripple effects, noting that freezing positions at the top tier would inevitably suppress promotional

THE 'VEL' OF WISDOM

THE recent kerfuffle about who 'owns' Lord Murugan left me marvelling at the larger picture. At how Murugan contains all the gods in his splendid self. Worship him, and you get every divine blessing from every source. Not only by relationship but also because all the deities bestowed their powers on him when he went to fight the demons and reclaim the world for us. Sri Krishna even says of his nephew in the *Bhagavad Gita*, Canto Ten, "Of generals, I am Skanda". Skanda means "One who leaps", a metaphor for Murugan's energy, softened to Kanda in Tamil.

Personally, I find Sanskrit rather formal for Murugan—love, though he is beautifully invoked in Adi Shankara's 'Subrahmanya Bhujangam'. Particularly in the verse that begins "Mayuradi roodam, Mahadeva gudam", meaning "Who rides a peacock, who contains the great truths", and tenderly ends, "Mahadeva baalam, bhaje lokapalam", meaning, "Young son of Shiva, and guardian of the world". New Skanda-seekers apparently chant "Om Subrahmanya Namah", meaning "I hail Lord Subrahmanya". To my mind, such formality distances him. The Shadashari or six-syllable Murugan mantra, "Om Saravana Bhaya", is the more direct call—just sharing my gut-feeling.

To 'understand' Murugan, we must perceive that he was the ultimate Gen Z. He had everything—a loving family, high position and universal acclaim. But when he felt wronged, he flew away leaving it all behind to become an ascetic on the hilltop of Pazhani, or Palani if 'zh' is difficult. Murugan is the beloved god of the Tamils because they chose each other. He renounced Kailash itself to be in their midst and is deeply embedded in 'Thamizhagam' and its culture.

In the ancient Tamil text *Tolkappiyam*, his name is Seyyon, meaning ruddy in complexion, while 'Senguruthi Seyyon' means born of divine fire. He is both a warrior and a lover of poetry; the guardian deity of Kuriñi (the Nilgiris) and represents the consonants and vowels of Tamil in his person. His six main abodes in Tamil Nadu are Thiruparankundam, Thiruchendur, Pazhani, Swamimalai, Thiruthani and Pazhamudicholai; and the Kukke Subrahmanya temple in Karnataka.

Murugan wants us to be straightforward and also enjoy the spice of mischief. Tamils will tell you fondly that he teases his devotees sometimes, disguised as a boy or old man. Beautiful himself, he likes an aesthetic approach.

however simple—red oleander, white jasmine and *vibhuti* (holy ash). Yet he is beyond the physical, as in the Indian philosophical concept of Nirgun, the formless 'Supersoul', acceptably seen as Sagan, a deity. This is profoundly expressed in the 14th-15th century in the poem 'Kandar Anubhuti' or 'Experience of Kanda', in the verse, "Uraivi arunai uladai lalai/Maruvai malalai maniyai olaiyi/Karuvai uyirai gattaiyai vidhiyai/Guruvai varuvai aruvai Guhane".



RENUKA NARAYANAN

FAITHLINE

Nobody has sung to Murugan as the Tamils have. Ancient historical texts fondly mention that he teases his devotees, sometimes disguised as a boy or old man. Yet to truly 'understand' him, Murugan must be perceived as the ultimate Gen Z.

This has deep unity with Upanishadic thought. It means, "You are with form and without form; you are that which is and that which is not; you are the unseen scent of a flower; the flower itself; you are sound and light. You are the embryo and, its refuge and our fate. Grace us as our guru, come to us, Hidden One (Guhu)." Likewise, the Upanishads call 'God' the 'essence'—the scent of a flower; ghee in milk and oil in the sesame seed. What's not to love in either?

The 18th-century 'Kanda Shashti Kavacham' by Devayana Swami is an influential, intimately known poem. Resident Tamils and the Tamil diaspora regularly hear it, some daily, some during the six-day fast of Skanda Shashti in October-November; on Thai Pusam in January-Fe-

bruary, the anniversary of Murugan defeating the demons with the *vel* (spear) given by Adi Shakti; and on Vaikasi Visakam, which was on May 30 this year, celebrating Murugan's appearance as six fiery sparks from Lord Shiva's third eye. Thus, nationalist poet Subrahmanya Bharati invoked Murugan to "come to us as the fire of courage", "bhuvane kanale varuga".

"*Azhagu deivam aaga vandhu*" is a hugely popular 20th-century song by freedom-fighter and litterateur-composer Periyar Thooran about how Tamils see Murugan—Kuzhandai aaga, Kumaran aaga, Kova-Nadai thurai aaga—that he came to them as a beautiful god, as a child, a youth, and the ascetic of Koval Nadi (Koval Nadi is the Coimbatore area, heartland of the larger historical region of Kongu Nadu in western Tamil Nadu where Pashana stands in today's Dindigul district).

Chanted like the 'Hanuman Chalisa' is in the North, 'Vel Maal Mahamantram' or 'Transformation by the Vel' by Vellimalai Sachidananda Swami is another powerful early 20th-century composition. *Vel* here means the spear of divine wisdom, while *maal* means change, reversal, or warding off. Together they signify the power of the *vel* to destroy negative forces and heal afflictions. The *kaapu* (shield) of the opening verse-cum-refrain says, "The powerful *vel* of Guha, who manifested at the sacred hill of Thiruthani, who is the peerless Supreme Being, the ancient lord of the mountains, who dwells forever in my heart as my deepest thoughts, who nobly rides the peacock."

By saying that the *vel* of *jnana shakti* (power of wisdom) belongs to the lord who lives in his heart, the poet asserts that divine wisdom lives within us to destroy the demons of ego, ignorance and past karmas. In Tamil, it goes, "Thiruthaniyil udith arulum/Oruthan malai viruthan/Enath' ulathil urai karuthan/Mayil nadathu Guhan vel". Its powerful meaning and rhythm can make the most downcast soul feel uplifted. Nobody has sung to Murugan as the Tamils have. It's unspoken, shrinking his splendour to politics. Share him, do, to spread the love.

(Views are personal) (sheebaba09@gmail.com)

the Attorney General's Department and clear chronic processing delays at the Government Analyst's Department. Pro-government legal groups have also pushed back against critics, arguing that extended or lifetime judicial appointments are standard practice in other constitutional systems and should not be opposed without reason.

As the government says determined to push for reforms including the postponement of retirements, the matter has drawn international scrutiny from oversight bodies such as LawAsia and the Commonwealth Lawyers' Association. Meanwhile, a high-profile court delivered capital sentences to a former defence secretary and a police chief over historical criminal negligence and security failures linked to the 2019 coordinated Easter Sunday bombings.

Yet the country is carefully watching the administration to see if it will allow further constitutional scrutiny to determine whether implementation requires a simple parliamentary majority or a national referendum, particularly on the question of piecemeal reform. At this point, the administration's motive is under the public microscope more than it seems to understand, creating a dent in public trust.

(Views are personal) (dibrukshi@cir.lk)

MAILBAG

WRITE TO: letters@newindianexpress.com

Funding access

Ref: New marketplace for philanthropy (Aug 2). The Social Stock Exchange is a welcome idea, bringing much-needed transparency to non-profit funding. But awareness remains low among smaller trusts and grassroots organisations that could benefit most. Simplifying onboarding norms and running outreach in regional languages would help these groups participate meaningfully, rather than leaving the platform accessible only to larger, well-resourced non-profits. **M Barathi, Chennai**

Resource division

In the public-sector bank I worked at, corporate social responsibility existed decades ago by its former name of 'innovative banking'. But the trouble today is that not all beneficiaries may belong to underserved segments. Rather, the art of giving should start from families. Even among siblings in a family, privileged and underprivileged co-exist. **P Mangalachandran, Kannur**

Economic order

Ref: Real disruption (Aug 2). The real transition is from a basic, mixed economy to a full-blown capitalist economy. This economic order has inherent weaknesses that make the system collapse on its own. Public resources are poured in increasingly to infuse life into the system. Persisting with this order only widens inequality and forces the government to sell public assets. **A G Rajahman, Anantapur**

Glasgow glory

Ref: Glasgow gold mine (Aug 2). Indian pugilists have done the nation proud at the Commonwealth Games. On the whole, Indian athletes have performed with panache and have overcome the odds against them. Though a few sports like badminton have not been a part of the Games this year, sports persons wearing the India emblem have proven that they are as good as their formidable rivals—if not better. With 13 gold medals in the kitty, Glasgow has turned into a happy hunting ground for Indian sports. **CV Arvind, email**

Homegrown talent

Ref: Making of a long jumper (Aug 2). Dedication and indigenous coaching can produce world champions—Sreesankar's journey proves that. His success reflects perseverance, resilience and faith. Investing in homegrown athletes and coaches will fortify our future. Their accomplishments deserve recognition and encouragement. **Muhammed Fasi, Kozhikode**

THE NEW INDIAN EXPRESS

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Resident Editor (Tamil Nadu): Anto T Joseph * Printed and Published by N Gopalan on behalf of Express Publications (Madurai) Private Ltd., at Express Press, 'Express Gardens', 29, Second Main Road, Ambattur Industrial Estate, Chennai - 600 058. Chennai: Vol. 96, No. 183, RNI Reg. No. TNENG/1002/57. Phone: 044-23457601, Fax: 044-23457619. * Responsible to decide the matter under the PRP Act. Copyright: Express Publications (Madurai) Private Ltd. All rights reserved. Reproduction in any manner, electronic or otherwise, in whole or in part, without prior written permission is prohibited.



07 CHENNAI



MONDAY 03.08.2026



Jairam Ramesh @Jairam_Ramesh

BJP governments cannot suppress legitimate grievances of working class, indigenous, and marginalised communities through arrests and draconian laws.



Akhilesh Yadav @yadavakhilesh

The truth is that even the BJP now knows they will never return to power, which is why they're not giving any importance to the Legislative Assembly.



Amrit Malviya @amritmalviya

Manufactured outrage and synchronised lectures won't diminish the stature of a leader who chooses reconciliation over retribution.

newindianexpress.com

SC to hear pleas on police crackdown during NEET paper leak protests today

SUCHITRA KALYAN MOHANTY
© New Delhi

tempt should be made to frame a protocol which will

40 intel units to be set up in Bengal border districts

Project to strengthen information-gathering system close to B'desh

INSIDER TRACK

Owning the night on social media

If BJP leaders are spending more time on Instagram these days, or rather nights, it isn't by accident. Ever since PM Narendra Modi nudged the party to connect better with Gen Z, the platform has become the latest outreach turf. And the new rule of engagement—post late. Party insiders say Modi's recent habit of putting out posts in



THE Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas alleging police brutality during the recent protests against irregularities in exams and the NEET paper leaks.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joydeep Bagchi and V Mohana will be hearing the pleas. The court had earlier indicated that it might constitute an SIT headed by a former Supreme Court judge for a probe into the allegations made by protesters and pellet gun victims to ascertain whether the attacks on policemen were carried out by students or "miscreants".

On July 28, the SC—while hearing a clutch of pleas against police excesses—said, "Why should there not be an independent probe into these allegations? Whoever has committed excesses or committed atrocities on innocent people, the law will take care of them. For that, there needs to be a completely independent and fair investigation. Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed," said the bench.

The top court also stressed that—while hearing the pleas against police excesses—

meet emergent situations in the future.

In its earlier 7-page order, the bench also restrained states from taking any coercive action against protesters in the student-led agitation and directed them to release those under 18 on the condition that none should have any criminal antecedents.

While protecting protesting students from coercive action, the bench made clear that it would not extend to those with criminal records. It permitted the Delhi government to continue investigations into the FIRs but said there should be no coercive action during the pendency of the proceedings.

"NCT of Delhi and other states may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered; however, no coercive measures shall be taken against the protesting students. Such protection, nonetheless, shall not be extended to the persons with criminal antecedents," the SC order read.

Senior advocate Vrinda Grover, while appearing for an applicant, referred to pellet injuries to some protesters during student protests and urged the SC to issue certain directions.

MUKESH RANJAN @ New Delhi

THE Centre has decided to strengthen its intelligence network along the India-Bangladesh border by setting up nearly 40 permanent Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau (SIB) units across border districts in West Bengal, with the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) seeking around 50 acres of land from the state government for the project, sources said.

The proposed expansion is aimed at enhancing intelligence gathering and counter-infiltration capabilities along the 2,217-km India-Bangladesh border, one of the country's most sensitive frontiers due to persistent concerns over illegal infiltration, cross-border smuggling, organised crime and other security threats, the sources said.

The move represents one of the largest expansions of the Intelligence Bureau's (IB) field infrastructure in the region in recent times and is intended to provide a permanent operational presence in vulnerable border sectors. The sources said the new units would improve the collection, analysis and dissemination of intelligence related to infiltration routes, smuggling syndicates, extremist activities and other



New units to bolster surveillance on infiltration routes

The new SIB units are expected to strengthen human intelligence capabilities by maintaining continuous surveillance over vulnerable sectors, identifying infiltration routes, monitoring suspicious movements and gathering actionable intelligence on organised criminal networks.

cross-border networks.

"Officials of the MHA and the West Bengal Home Department have held discussions on the implementation of the project, including identification of suitable land parcels for the proposed establishments. Under the plan, each SIB unit will require between one and 1.5 acres of land, taking the total requirement to nearly 50 acres across several border districts," a source said.

Once the land is transferred by the state government, the IB will develop the facilities independently. Unlike many existing SIB units that currently op-

erate from rented premises outside Kolkata, the new establishments will be designed as permanent office-cum-residential campuses. "Permanent campuses are expected to improve operational secrecy by offering secure communication systems, protected records management and surveillance infrastructure essential for handling national security information," an official said.

Although the India-Bangladesh border stretches across five states, West Bengal accounts for the longest section. Nearly 600 km of the border remains unfenced.

the evening is deliberate, catching young users when they are most active. Ministers and leaders have quickly fallen in line, with selfie videos multiplying and even family members being encouraged to pitch in online. Sources say Instagram activity among BJP leaders has jumped by 45-60 per cent.

The next target? Push the party's combined follower base, already above 125 million, to the next milestone.



Keeping fixers out of tourism PSU

ITDC has decided enough is enough. After noticing former employees and a few well-connected outsiders trying to smooth-talk customers, vendors and officials in commercial matters without any formal authorisation, the tourism PSU has drawn a firm line. No retired employee, or an "external" person(s), it says, can present themselves as an authorised go-between without written approval. Serving officials have also been told to ignore unofficial recommendations on everything from bookings and discounts to vendor approvals. And if anyone invokes old contacts at ITDC Hotels, Resorts & Tours or any other division to influence decisions, the message is simple: inform the Vigilance Division immediately.



No easy moves for the top spot

Just as the Congress appears to have untangled the Karnataka Cabinet knot, Rahul Gandhi has another political Rubik's Cube waiting for him—finding a new Kerala PCC president. Sunny Joseph has been juggling the party post and a Cabinet berth since May, leaving the organisation waiting for a full-time chief. With five contenders and three influential camps in play, choosing one without upsetting the others will prove challenging. The rumour mill says Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge is said to favour Dalit leader Kodikunni Suresh, while Priyanka Gandhi Vadra is believed to be backing Anto Ananth. K C Venugopal is said to be pitching for young MP Shaifali Paramebi. Benny Behanan and Mathew Kuzhalnadan, too, remain in the reckoning.

When files start talking

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) feels simply reading CAG reports is no longer enough. So, it's asking tough questions: if audit reports point to negligence and irregularities, what is stopping the government from acting against the babbles concerned, including serving and former secretaries? For years, audit findings have only ended with explanations, file notings and promises of corrective measures. Inside the bureaucracy, the question is said to have caused more than a little discomfort. That is often when the search for a scapegoat begins. Consultants, lateral-entry officers and professionals in PSUs, semi-government and autonomous bodies find themselves carrying blame for decisions they neither initiated nor controlled. They make easier targets than entrenched officials.

EXPRESS READ

Cyclotron to celebrate India's Independence

A symbolic 79-km cyclotron, with riders consisting of 79 NCC cadets, was held here on Sunday to mark 79 years of India's Independence, officials said. The cyclotron was flagged off by Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya in the presence of Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Sethi, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, among others.

Rail line through tiger corridor gets approval

A railway line construction, which will claim more than 200 hectares of forest land within a tiger corridor between Satpura Tiger Reserve in Madhya Pradesh and Melghat Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra, has been given in-principle clearance by the Standing Committee of National Board for Wildlife. The corridor is a crucial stretch, ensuring the continuity of forests in Satpura.

'Rahul worried about PM popularity among youth'



LoP Rahul Gandhi feels threatened because of the growing popularity of PM Modi. Piyush Goyal, Union Minister

'No law under UPA govt'

Piyush Goyal claimed the Congress-led UPA govt had planned a legislation on examination paper leaks in 2010-11 but lacked the courage to introduce it.

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ New Delhi

UNION Minister and senior BJP leader Piyush Goyal on Sunday claimed that Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi "feels threatened" by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's growing popularity among young people, saying Gandhi no longer enjoys the appeal he once believed he had among the youth.

Claiming that the BJP continued to enjoy the support of young voters, Goyal said "Gen Z was always with us". He said young people would continue to back Modi's vision of making India a developed nation.

Describing Modi as the world's "most popular leader", the Mumbai North MP said the prime minister's engagement with young people and presence across social media platforms would help accelerate the country's development.

"Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi feels threatened because of the growing popularity of PM Modi and the way he is connecting with the youth. Gandhi used to consider himself as a youth leader. It has been proven that he is no longer

as popular as PM Modi," Goyal told reporters.

Responding to questions on the youth protests at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, which later culminated in the resignation of Dharmaendra Pradhan as Union education minister, Goyal defended the Centre's handling of examination paper leaks, saying the government had enacted stringent legislation under Modi's leadership.

He claimed the Congress-led UPA government had planned legislation on examination paper leaks in 2010-11 but lacked the courage to introduce it. The NDA government under Modi enacted such a law in 2024, Goyal said.

He added that Opposition parties, including the Congress, Samajwadi Party and Aam Aadmi Party, had opposed the legislation in Parliament. "I can understand their disappointment and frustration as voters are rejecting them again and again. They are losing elections one after another. When the Bill was being discussed, they should have supported it. I condemn the Congress, Samajwadi Party, AAP etc for opposing the Bill," Goyal said.



Behind every statistic is a child with a dream, a family living with an irreplaceable loss. Rahul Gandhi, Congress MP

Pappu Yadav attacked

A man threw a slipper at MP Pappu Yadav during a press conference on Sunday. Police sources say that the man belongs to UP's Bulandshahr.

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ New Delhi

CONGRESS leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday sharpened his attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the alleged NEET examination irregularities, saying students do not need the Prime Minister's "forgiveness" and that it is the government that owes them "truth, justice and an apology".

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha made the remarks after meeting families of three Tamil Nadu medical aspirants—Gopika, Roshini and Vetri Anandan—who allegedly died by suicide following the NEET paper leak and the subsequent cancellation of the examination. Gandhi met the bereaved families during his visit to Tamil Nadu on Saturday and later shared a video of the interaction on Instagram.

Describing the meetings as deeply moving, Gandhi said each family was haunted by the same question: why honest and hardworking students should suffer because of a "dishonest system". "A leaked paper led to a cancelled examination, a forced re-test and unbearable

pressure on young minds. Behind every statistic is a child with a dream and a family living with an irreplaceable loss," Gandhi said.

He asserted that the Congress' fight was for an education system where merit is rewarded, examinations are conducted fairly and students are not forced to bear the consequences of institutional failures. "The Prime Minister speaks of 'forgiving' students. After listening to these parents, my conviction is even stronger: India's students need no forgiveness. The government owes them truth, justice and an apology," Gandhi said.

In a separate post on X, Gandhi said the grief of the affected families would remain lifelong and questioned the accountability of institutions responsible for conducting competitive examinations.

Meanwhile, Congress' media and publicity department head Pawan Khara also took a swipe at Modi's remarks. Sharing the Prime Minister's video on X, he said, "The country is asking him to apologise, yet he has forgiven the country."

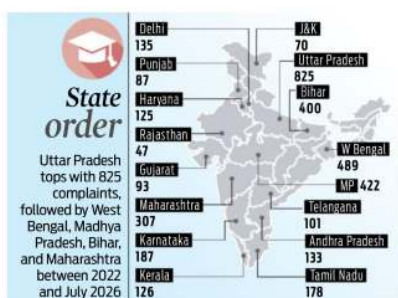
Ragging complaints rise despite strict measures

HASPREET RAJWA @ Chandigarh

DESPITE stringent measures and regulations, ragging continues nationwide. Uttar Pradesh tops with 825 ragging complaints, followed by West Bengal with 489 cases, Madhya Pradesh with 422, Bihar accounting for 400 cases, and Maharashtra with 307 complaints reported from 2022 to July 22 this year.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Education Dr Sukanta Majumdar informed that this year, till July 22 alone, 521 ragging complaints have been received across higher educational institutions. Uttar Pradesh recorded 135 complaints, West Bengal 75, Madhya Pradesh 63, Maharashtra 53, and Bihar 50. Last year, out of the total of 963 ragging complaints across the country, UP recorded 251 complaints, followed by Bihar (122), MP (117), West Bengal (102) and Maharashtra (89).

The number of ragging cases has seen a steady increase across India. In 2024, the number was 759, and in 2023 it



was 655, and in 2022, 457 complaints across the country.

As far as Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir are concerned, Haryana accounts for nearly half the complaints in the past five years with 125 cases, followed by Punjab with 87 complaints, J&K with 70, Himachal Pradesh with 44 and Union Ter-

ritory of Chandigarh with 4.

The issue of ragging again came to focus this January when Himachal Pradesh Police registered a case against three girl students after a 19-year-old student of Government Degree College alleged she suffered physical abuse and humiliation during a ragging incident. The student later died.

While in neighbouring Haryana, last year a case of alleged ragging by a junior MBBS student against a senior student was reported at a medical college, which was investigated by the anti-ragging committee.

Rajasthan holds the sixth position at 247 registered complaints, and Delhi accounts for 135 complaints and Uttarakhand with 142 cases.

While in the southern states, Odisha registered the highest number of complaints in the last five years with 227 cases, followed by Karnataka (187), Tamil Nadu (178), Andhra Pradesh (133), Kerala (126), Telangana (101) and Pondicherry (7).

Talking about the eastern and northeastern states of the country, 489 complaints from West Bengal; 162 from Andaman & Nicobar Islands; 2 from Assam; 17 from Tripura, 11 from Arunachal Pradesh; 9 each from Meghalaya and Mizoram; 8 from Manipur; 6 from Sikkim; and 1 from Nagaland.

The reply said UGC had issued notices to 107 higher educational institutions.

Minorities file over 9,000 grievances in four years, Muslims lead in the list

RAJESH KUMAR THAKUR @ New Delhi

MINORITY communities, including Muslims, Christians and Sikhs, filed 9,550 grievances with the National Commission for Minorities (NCM) between 2021-22 and 2025-26, covering a range of issues. Muslims accounted for the highest number of complaints lodged during the period, according to data from the Ministry of Minority Affairs.

Out of 9,557 grievances lodged with the NCM from across the country, the highest number of 2,059 were related to law and order and 1,031 to land disputes. Only 31 grievances were related to communal violence and 97 to hate crimes and hate speeches.

Muslims filed 6,145 grievances between 2021-22 and 2025-26, followed by 1,222 filed by Sikhs and 644 by Christians. The complaints covered education, law and order, land disputes, religious rights, and economic



1,699 grievances were received in 2025-26

Providing a year-wise break-up, the ministry said 2,076 grievances were received from minority communities in 2021-22, followed by 2,423 in 2022-23, 1,999 in 2023-24, 1,390 in 2024-25 and 1,699 in 2025-26. In 2025-26, the NCM received the highest number of 577 grievances from Muslims, compared with 378 in 2021-22.

Among the states, Uttar Pradesh reported the highest number of grievances with 3,484 filed by Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Buddhists, Parsis, Jains and others.

Delhi followed with 1,140 grievances. Maharashtra with 690, Punjab (512), Telangana (392), Madhya Pradesh (381), Haryana (324) and Bihar (301). "The commission disposed of all grievances as expeditiously as possible," the ministry said in reply to an MP's question.

Providing a year-wise break-up, the ministry stated that 2,076 grievances were received from minority communities in 2021-22, followed by 2,423 in 2022-23, 1,999 in 2023-24, 1,390 in 2024-25 and 1,699 in 2025-26. In 2025-26, the NCM received the highest number of 577 grievances from Muslims, compared with 378 in 2021-22. Initially, NCM recognised five religious communities—Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists and Zoroastrians (Parsis).

Security up in migrant areas in J&K

Forces increase watch in neighbourhoods inhabited by outside labourers, Kashmiri Pandits

FAYAZ WANI @ Srinagar

AFTER the back-to-back terror attacks targeting a policeman and migrant labourers in Kashmir, authorities have beefed up security in areas where migrant workers and Kashmiri Pandits reside and put in place additional measures for smooth conduct of Amarnath yatra.

A security official said a massive manhunt has been launched to track down the attackers involved in the July 22 killing of the policeman in busy Lal Chowk area of Anantnag and the recent killing of two migrant labourers from Chhattisgarh in Kulgam. "Security forces immediately cordoned off the area after the attack on the labourers at a brick kiln in Kilam area of Kulgam and launched extensive search operations in the adjoining localities to trace the attackers," the official said.

According to sources, preliminary investigation has indicated that two terrorists were involved in the attack. "One of them fired on the labourers and another provided cover. Both fled from the scene immediately after carrying out the attack," an official said. Some suspects have been detained for questioning as investigators attempt to identify over-ground workers (OGWs) who facilitated the terrorists, the sources said.



Police personnel along the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway on Sunday | Im

Lashkar member key suspect for twin attacks

Officials said the name of Latief Bhat, a local terrorist associated with the Lashkar-e-Taiba, has surfaced during the probe of both the attacks. Latief had escaped during an encounter with security forces in Shopian earlier this month while another terrorist Zakir Ahmed was killed.

After the killing of the policeman in Anantnag by a lone terrorist on July 22, security agencies detained over 3,500 alleged OGWs for questioning. Sources said the name of Latief Bhat, a local terrorist associated with the Lashkar-e-Taiba, has surfaced during the probe of both the attacks.

Latief had escaped during an encounter with security forces in Shopian earlier this month. Latief along with another local terrorist Zakir Ahmed were trapped in the Shopian encounter. While Zakir was killed in the five-day operation, Latief managed to escape.

After the twin attacks, security agencies have intensified

surveillance. Police, army and paramilitary personnel have intensified patrolling and set up check points, where commuters are being frisked. A security official said security deployment has been increased in areas where migrant labourers and migrant Kashmiri Pandits reside.

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, while chairing a security review meeting, directed officials for a comprehensive review of the standard operating procedures established to protect migrant labourers. The security official said security arrangements have been beefed up for the pilgrims during the ongoing Amarnath yatra.

Farooq asks how terrorists get to enter the valley

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE @ Srinagar

A day after demanding a thorough investigation into the killing of two Chhattisgarh labourers in a terror attack, ruling National Conference president Farooq Abdullah on Sunday said the attackers must be identified. He also asked the authorities where the terrorists were coming from when all borders are sealed.

"The terrorists killed a police officer and two labourers. Tell us who these killers are. You say terrorism has ended. If terrorism has ended, then who is killing people," Abdullah told reporters in Bijnbehara in south Kashmir. "People are being killed and then it is being said terrorists killed them. But the question is where the terrorists come from when all the borders are sealed," Abdullah asked.

On Saturday, the NC president had questioned the timing of the attack, saying "I do not know why such incidents happen whenever we are demanding standard for J&K."

Former CM and PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti termed the attack a security lapse.

Punjab Cong faction fight continues; miffed ex-CM's supporters raise slogans

HARPREET BAJWA @ Chandigarh

FACTIONALISM in the Punjab Congress came out in the open again on Sunday as slogans were raised in support of MP and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi during a party programme at Barnala in the presence of state party president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and AICC in-charge Bhupesh Baghel.

Channi is miffed over the AICC decision to retain Warring as the state president ahead of assembly elections scheduled for next year. Supporters are persistent in their demand to make Channi as the state president.

On Saturday, supporters of Channi and Warring clashed at a party meeting in Sangrur and almost came to blows in Patiala in the presence of Baghel. During the 'Har' booth, Congress mazzboot' event at Barnala on Sunday, slogans were raised for making Channi the state Congress president to bolster party's prospects in assembly polls. Local MLA Kuldeep Singh Kala Dhillon and former ministers Brahm Mohindra, Raj Kumar Verka and Razia Sultana were also present on the stage. Channi was not present at the meeting.



Former CM Charanjit Singh Channi

In an attempt to maintain order, Warring said every party worker has the right to express his/her views but stressed that organisational discipline is important. "The whole effort will go waste, no slogans please," he said. Razia Sultana said anyone with a complaint should take it up with the party high command. Kaka Dhillon tried to pacify those raising slogans. Baghel raised slogans in support of Warring. Channi, Partap Bajwa, Sukhinder Randhawa, Brahm Mohindra and Razia Sultana.

After the function, Warring said he has no objection if someone raises slogans in support of Channi. "If one person raises a slogan in support of Channi, it is projected as if pro-Pakistan slogans were raised at our meeting," he said.



PATNA DIARY

RAMSHANKAR
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'Hunter wall madam' new BSSC chairman

The Bihar government has made a major administrative reshuffle by appointing 1990-batch (retired) IPS officer Shobha Chakraborty as the new chairman of the Bihar Staff Selection Commission (BSSC). The General Administration Department has issued a notification. Chakraborty, who retired from the post of director general of the Home Guards and Fire Services on June 30, will now take charge of the commission, which has earlier been mired in controversy. When Chakraborty was in service, she earned the sobriquet of 'Hunter Walli Madam' for her tough actions. With this appointment, it is expected that the commission's functioning will gain momentum.



Dry tippers rush to neighbouring states

More and more people from dry Bihar are visiting religious places like Deogarh in Jharkhand and Varanasi in UP to consume alcohol. During an awareness programme at Lok Bhawan in Patna, even CM Samrat Choudhary admitted, "I know people from Bihar have started visiting places like Deogarh, Varanasi, and Kushinagar frequently since there is no prohibition in those places, whereas complete prohibition is in force in Bihar. Some people travel to those states for worshipping deities or other reasons, but the impact of prohibition in public places is clearly visible in Bihar." He, however, credited ex-CM Nitish Kumar for declaring the state dry.

Panchayati raj minister saves his son's chair

Bihar Panchayati Raj minister Deepak Prakash is likely to continue on the post even after the Supreme Court's adverse remarks against him. After the apex court sought to know from the Bihar government as to how Prakash was serving as a minister without being a member of the House, BJP MP C. Devesh Kumar was asked to resign from membership of Bihar Legislative Council to pave way for Prakash's nomination as a member of the Upper House. Prakash's father, Upendra Kushwaha, a former union minister, managed to save his son's ministerial berth. A political activist rightly observed, "After all, the issue concerned his son's political career."

LEOPARDS

Inter-state gang of poachers busted in MP

ANURAG SINGH @ Bhopal

AN inter-state gang of poachers, which killed ten leopards within nine months in the jungles of northern Madhya Pradesh (Gwalior-Chambal region), including the Kuno Wildlife Division, has been busted following a series of operations by the forest department and police in Madhya Pradesh and adjoining Uttar Pradesh.

As many as 11 people associated with the racket have been arrested in the two states—four in UP and seven in Madhya Pradesh—and more arrests are likely in the coming days. On July 23, a joint team of forest and police departments in UP's Agra nabbed four men, including two Haryana natives and two men hailing from northern MP. Ten leopard skins and other body parts were seized from arrested persons.

Following operations in the western UP district, the MP forest department's state tiger strike force formed multiple teams, which were sent to UP, parts of northern MP and Haryana. Based on the inputs from those arrested, police probed further and nabbed seven more people, six of whom were natives of Jhar Bardo, a village of Sheopur, while another man hailed from Morena.

Pregnant women's helps to get ₹300 daily in U'khand to stay in waiting homes

NARENDRA SETHI @ Dehradun

IN a move aimed at improving maternal healthcare in remote mountain regions, the Uttarakhand National Health Mission (NHM) will provide ₹300 a day to attendants accompanying pregnant women to the state's birth waiting homes.

The attendants will also receive free accommodation and meals. The initiative seeks to compensate them for the daily wages they lose while remaining with expectant mothers ahead of delivery. Uttarakhand has 52 birth waiting homes across its districts, each equipped to accommodate three pregnant women at a time. However, only 299 women used these facilities last year, prompting the NHM to review the reasons behind the low uptake and introduce additional incentives.

Birth waiting homes allow women from remote villages to stay near a health facility as their expected delivery date approaches. The arrangement is particularly important in the hill districts, where difficult terrain, long distances and inadequate road connectivity often delay access to hospitals.

The facilities become more critical during the monsoon, when heavy rain and landslides



Facility for hill districts

Birth waiting homes allow women from remote villages to stay near a health facility as their expected delivery date approaches. The arrangement is particularly important in the hill districts.

frequently block roads in mountainous and far-flung areas. Such disruptions can make it difficult, and sometimes impossible, for women in labour to reach hospitals in time.

"Fifty-two birth waiting homes are currently operational across the state, and 299 pregnant women benefited from them last year," NHM Mission Director Dr Sandeep Tiwari said. "The objective is to support women living in remote areas where roads are unavailable or villages are located far from motorable routes. Women nearing their delivery date can stay at these homes until childbirth," he added.

18,404 Gujarat cooperatives in losses, 10% non-functional

DILIP SINGH KSHATRIYA @ Ahmedabad

ALTHOUGH Gujarat figures among India's strongest cooperative states, fresh data placed before the Rajya Sabha reveals that its celebrated cooperative movement is battling an internal crisis.

While Gujarat has one of the country's largest cooperative networks, thousands of societies have either stopped functioning or slipped into financial distress, raising questions over long-term sustainability.

According to the Ministry of Cooperation, Gujarat has 88,119 registered cooperative societies, making it the second largest cooperative ecosystem in India after Maharashtra's 2.27 lakh societies. Gujarat alone accounts for over 10% of all cooperative societies in the country, underlining its strategic importance in India's cooperative economy.

However, the headline figures conceal significant structural weaknesses.

Out of 88,119 registered societies, 79,823 are functional, but 6,959 have become non-functional, while another 1,341 are under liquidation. In other words, 8,300 cooperative societies in Gujarat are effectively inactive or on the verge of closure, representing nearly one



in every ten registered societies in the state.

The financial health of the functioning societies paints another mixed picture. Among the 79,823 operational cooperatives, 56,977 are profit-making, indicating that nearly 71% of active societies remain financially viable. But 18,404 societies are operating at a loss, accounting for almost 23% of all functional cooperatives. Financial information is unavailable for another 4,442 societies, making it difficult to assess the true financial health of the sector.

Data suggests that while Gujarat has succeeded in expanding the cooperative network,

financial sustainability remains uneven across the sector. Across India, there are 8.53 lakh cooperative societies, of which 6.83 lakh are functional, 1.41 lakh are non-functional, and 49,177 are under liquidation. Among functioning societies, 3.56 lakh are profit-making, 2.50 lakh are loss-making, while financial data is unavailable for 56,689 societies.

Although Gujarat performs better than several states in terms of the proportion of operational societies, the existence of thousands of dormant cooperatives indicates persistent governance, management and financial challenges.

Haryana cracks 48 drug cases with canine help

HARPREET BAJWA @ Chandigarh

IN Haryana's relentless fight against narcotics, an unlikely battalion has emerged as one of law enforcement's most lethal assets—the trained sniffer dogs of the State Police.

The top performers, Bolt (HK132) led the pack with 15 successful cases, followed by Rambo (HK133) with 14 and Romeo (HK131) with 12 cases and thus these dogs cracked 48 NDPS cases in first six months of this year.

Rambo's biggest contribution came with the largest seizure—5 quintals, 50 kg and 300 gram of drug post.

The first six months of this year witnessed a series of major seizures assisted by sniffer



Trained noses sniff narcotics in vehicles, buildings

Across these operations, trained sniffer dogs—Bolt, Rambo, Romeo, Jagga, Jack, Sheru, Tom, Bruno, Jimmy, Raja, Jesifer, Max, Mahi and Charlie—used their exceptional scenting ability to detect narcotics hidden in vehicles, buildings, warehouses and other locations.

raids and search operations to crack 48 NDPS cases.

Among the notable recover-

ies of cannabis, 105.08 g of charas, besides heroin and other narcotics recovered in separate

operations in vehicles, buildings, warehouses and other locations, repeatedly turning intelligence inputs into successful arrests and seizures.

The Hissar Dog Squad Unit recorded the best overall performance among all units during the first half of 2026. Bolt, the unit's lead sniffer dog, participated in the highest number of raids and search operations, contributing to 15 NDPS cases. Brigadier Sandeep Singh Kashyap (Retd), a consultant with the Haryana Police, said that every sniffer dog and handler undergo specialised training based on modern scientific methods.

Haryana Director General of Police Ajay Singhal said the force's sniffer dogs and their

C'garh women turn Raksha Bandhan into 'gift for earth, love for brothers'

EJAZ KAISER @ Raipur

THIS Raksha Bandhan, the sacred thread tied around brothers' wrists will celebrate more than just the bond between siblings—it will double up as a return gift to Earth.

In a novel initiative themed "Love on Brother's Wrist, a Gift to Mother Earth," in Chhattisgarh's Raigarh district, about 200 km east of Raipur, the women from Self-Help Groups (SHGs) under the National Rural Livelihoods Mission (Bihar) are crafting unique, eco-friendly 'seed rakshis'.

The standout feature of the threads is the integration of in-



these discarded rakshis will naturally dissolve into the soil. As the monsoon rain hits, the embedded seeds will germinate into lush plants.

Guided by District Collector Mayank Chaturvedi and supported by the Zila Panchayat

have wholeheartedly thrown themselves into crafting these eco-conscious threads.

Self-Help Groups across Raigarh (Baispali, Junwani, Loring, Gopalpur, and Sambalpur), Lailunga, Tamar (Janani Group in Libra village), Gharghoda (Gayatri Group in Badegumda), and Pusaur (Putkaspur Cluster) are actively creating these eco-threads.

To encourage creativity and local innovation, a district-wide competition will select the single best seed rakhi from each of the seven blocks. Entries will be evaluated based on design aesthetics, effective use of local seeds, and the clarity

dogs, involving chitta, smack, cannabis, charas, doka post, chura post, opium and other narcotic substances. The joint teams of the Haryana State Narcotics Control Bureau (HNCB) and district police used sniffer dogs in targeted

operations. Across these operations, trained sniffer dogs—Bolt, Rambo, Romeo, Jagna, Jack, Sheru, Tom, Bruno, Jimmy, Raja, Jesifer, Max, Mahi and Charlie—used their exceptional scenting ability to detect nar-

handlers have become a crucial link in the anti-drug campaign. "Their extraordinary scenting ability, scientific training and close operational coordination proved decisive in tracking down narcotics and exposing trafficking networks," he said.

ditional seeds, including paddy, maize, corn, hyacinth beans (semi), bitter gourd (karela), and cowpea (barbati). Beautifully arranged with natural materials, these seeds are embedded into the design.

Once the festival concludes, Raigarh, the green drive aims to connect the festive spirit with environmental conservation. The initiative has sparked widespread enthusiasm across all seven blocks of Raigarh. Women entrepreneurs and kishi sakhis (agricultural allies)

of their eco-friendly message. The winners from all seven blocks will be honoured at a special ceremony. The winning SHG members will tie their rakhs on the wrists of the District Collector and other senior officials.

of their eco-friendly message. The winners from all seven blocks will be honoured at a special ceremony. The winning SHG members will tie their rakhs on the wrists of the District Collector and other senior officials.



WORLD

13 dead

after small tourist plane crashes in Peru



GLOBAL WEATHER

COUNTRY	Max	Min	TDS
Australia (Perth)	13	0	SNV
India (Delhi)	26	19	LR
Italy (Rome)	37	24	SNV
Japan (Tokyo)	37	26	LR
Malaysia (Kuala Lumpur)	31	25	LR
Maldives (Male)	29	26	LR
Mauritius (Port Louis)	27	21	SNV
Singapore	32	28	TDS
South Korea (Seoul)	35	27	LR
Switzerland (Bern)	28	17	LR
Thailand (Bangkok)	32	27	LR
Turkey (Ankara)	28	15	SNV
UAE (Dubai)	39	34	SNV
Vietnam (Hanoi)	31	26	TDS

09 CHENNAI MONDAY 03.08.2026

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TRUMP PAUSES IRAN STRIKES, SEEKS RAPID DEAL TO END WAR

Claims decision taken after 'requests' from Iran & Wasia nations, says US remains 'locked & loaded'

WASHINGTON

PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Saturday that the United States and Israel had agreed to hold off on new strikes on Iran — provided that a deal to end the months-long conflict is reached rapidly.

Fears had been mounting that the fighting could escalate once again after Trump threatened to hit Iran "very hard" and was reportedly considering renewed heavy attacks, including against energy infrastructure. But the US leader appeared to have changed course after speaking with Saudi Arabia's crown prince and after Tehran also spoke to Riyadh, and to mediators Paki-

stan and Turkey.

Trump insisted the US was "locked and loaded and ready to go against the Islamic Republic of Iran," but added that "we have just been asked by Iran, and other West Asian countries, to hold off any attack." "Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL," Trump posted on his Truth Social platform.

Iran's Mehr news agency, citing military officials, called

Trump's claim that Tehran asked him to refrain "nothing but a new lie" and said Iran's military was "on high alert and ready for any eventuality".

Iranian state media said the Saudi and Iranian foreign ministers held a call and that Tehran also spoke with Pakistan and Turkey, which have acted as mediators in the talks, about "the risk of escalating tensions and insecurity in the region".

Saudi Arabia's official SPA press agency said Crown Prince Mohammed Bin Salman had a call with Trump where he "emphasised the necessity of pri-

oritising dialogue to reduce tensions and the importance of exerting all possible efforts to achieve a truce that paves the way for diplomatic solutions".

The US president said the deal would have to include the "immediate, complete and total opening of the hormuz strait, and an end to Iran's nuclear threat." "The Country of Israel joins me in this commitment," he added. More than five months after the US and Israel launched strikes on Tehran on February 28, the war shows no sign of ending. A previous ceasefire, which included reopening the Strait of Hormuz, collapsed, and Iran has since tightened control of the vital waterway as hostilities resumed. AFP

Israel says it has serious concerns with Hamas deal

TEL AVIV

ISRAEL has shared "serious security concerns" with the White House regarding the proposed disarmament deal with Hamas, an Israeli official said Sunday in what were some of the first public comments since U.S. President Donald Trump announced the agreement.

Doron Spielman, spokesperson for the Israeli Prime Minister's office, told The Associated Press on Sunday the AP that Israel's intelligence assessment is that Hamas remains committed to rebuilding its military

rather than genuinely demilitarizing. He said the Israeli military would not withdraw from Gaza where it controls more than 60% of the territory — before Hamas disarms.

"Our assessment is that if we redeploy before Hamas is truly disarmed, it will quickly expand its presence throughout Gaza, rebuild its terrorist infrastructure, once again threaten Israeli communities, and seek to carry out another Oct. 7-style attack," he said, referring to the Hamas militant attack on Israel in 2023 that triggered the war in the Gaza Strip. AP

Efforts underway to revive June US-Iran deal, says Iranian MP

TEHRAN: Mediators are trying to revive the Islamabad agreement that briefly halted the Iran-US war in June, an Iranian lawmaker said on Sunday. Hassan Ghasghaui, spokesman for parliament's national security commission, said talks were focused on reopening the Strait of Hormuz, calling it the "key" issue. The Qatar- and Pakistan-backed deal had included restoring diplomatic relations between Tehran and Washington, as well as ending hostilities involving Israel and Hezbollah, but later collapsed amid mutual accusations of violations.



ISRAELI STRIKES KILL 13 IN GAZA

GAZA CITY: At least 13 people were killed in Israeli strikes on residential buildings across Gaza on Sunday, authorities said, despite Hamas agreeing to the latest stage of a US-backed plan to end the war. Israel has not endorsed the deal, with an official saying there would be no troop withdrawal without Hamas' "genuine disarmament". The deal included women and children in strikes on Gaza City, Khan Younis, Jabalia and Deir al-Balah. Gaza's civil defence said several apartments and a vehicle were hit in the attacks. The Israeli military said some strikes targeted members of the Army of Islam and Islamic Jihad militant groups. Hamas on Friday accepted a plan to disarm and gradually withdraw Israeli forces.

Suicide bomber attacks rally in Pakistan's Swat Valley; 14 dead

PESHAWAR

At least 14 people, including five security men, were killed and over a dozen injured in a suicide attack on a police station during a peace rally in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan on Sunday, officials said.

The explosion occurred when the Swat Peace Rally was in progress right across the police station in Kabal town in Swat district. No group or individual has claimed immediate responsibility for the attack.

Nine bodies were shifted to Central Hospital Saidu Sharif, while doctors at Kabal Hospital confirmed five more fatalities, taking the total number of confirmed deaths to 14, a Rescue 1122 Swat spokesperson said.

The Swat Peace Rally was organised by Swat Aman Jirga (local tribal council) with participants raising slogans and carrying placards to demand peace in the area. They alleged that police inaction has resulted in deterioration in the security situation in the past few months. Police said the suspected suicide bomber was stopped at the gate of Kabal Police Station. The attacker then detonated the explosive device, damaging the main gate and preventing entry into the heavily secured compound, the DPO said. PTI

Two firefighting copters collide midair as Athens wildfire rages



Greek firefighters extinguishing wildfire in Porto Germeno, some 70 kilometres northwest of Athens in Viotia | AFP

ATHENS

TWO Greek firefighting helicopters collided in midair on Sunday as they were battling a wind-driven wildfire west of Athens, sending one aircraft crashing to the ground, footage showed. The four crew members were recovered, the Greek fire department said. Two were recovered safely while the other two were unconscious. No further details about their condition was immediately available.

The collision laid bare the danger at the most volatile front of Europe's wildfire emergency. Strong winds drove flames deeper into the region of the Greek capital and forced fresh evacuations. France guarded a still-burning scar four times the size of Paris, while Spain's major fires stopped advancing. The aircraft were Bell helicopters operating over the Psatha area west of Athens, each with a two-person crew. Two of those aboard were Greek and

two were foreign nationals, but authorities did not identify their countries.

Flames spread rapidly through western Attica, threatening communities and an industrial district outside Megara as violent gusts prevented firefighting aircraft from collecting water from the sea. The advance carried grim resonance in a region where the 2018 Mati wildfire killed 104 people, Europe's deadliest blaze this century. Further west, containment brought no end to the emergency. France's largest wildfire remained held within its perimeter after forcing 22,000 people to flee in what may have been the country's largest civilian evacuation outside wartime.

Hot spots still burned within a 40-square-kilometre scar; thousands remained unable to return home, and nearly 3,000 firefighters were deployed against the Gironde megafire and a second, still-uncontained blaze in Provence. Wildfires in France and Spain have forced about 300,000 people to flee and stretched emergency services. AP

EXPRESS READ

Bodies of Purja, three other climbers found

KATHMANDU: Bodies of British-Nepali climber Nirmal Purja and three others have been recovered on Sunday from Broad Peak after an avalanche swept away a 10-member expedition. Search teams continue looking for two

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Auction for Sale of Sun Flower Procured by TS

MARKED DURING YASANGI 2025-26

Tender notification for online e-auction on disposal of Sun Flower (Yasangi) (Rabi) 2025-26 procured by TCM MARKED auction for the quantity and lots as mentioned in the e-auction portal through <https://auction.telanganacmf.com/> or <https://telanganacmf.com/>. Applications in e-procurement portal will be available from 11:30 AM on 03.08.2026. I. E-auction bidding will commence on 11.08.2026 from 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM

Indian Bank

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

APPENDIX IV-A (See Proviso to Rule 8(i))

E-Enforcement Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(i) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the secured creditor(s) that the schedule mentioned immovable properties mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of respective accounts of Indian Bank, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis for recovery of amount due specified for each of the accounts thereto, which is due to the Secured Creditor, with further interest, costs, other charges and expenses thereon.

1. NAME AND ADDRESS OF THE BORROWERS/GUARANTORS/MORTGAGORS: (1) M/s. KKA AND COMPANY, (Borrower), No. 3 & 4, Ground Floor, Old No. 112, New No. 14, Francis Joseph Street, Parys, Chennai - 600 001. (2) Mr. Muzaffar Ibrahim, (Partner), S/o Mohamed Mustafa, 101/3, 120, Pichayar Kall Street, Sowmya, Chennai - 600 007. (3) Mr. Rajmouli, (Partner/Guarantor), No. 73/2, Devanar Street, Triplicane, Chennai - 600 005. (4) Mrs. Hamedha Banu, (Guarantor), W/o Najmuddin, No. 73, Devanar Street, Triplicane, Chennai - 600 005. (5) Mr. Mahabub Khan, (Guarantor), S/o Asad, 43, Units All Street, Ellis Road, Anna Salai, Chennai - 600 002. (Branch Name: Indian Bank, Penur Branch (now transferred to SAM Branch, Chennai)). TOTAL AMOUNT DUE TO THE BANKS ON 28.07.2026: Rs. 3,18,22,712.87 (Rupees Three crores eighteen lakhs twenty two thousand seven hundred twelve and paise seventy one only) with further interest from 29.07.2026, other charges and expenses thereon.

2. NAME AND ADDRESS OF THE BORROWERS/GUARANTORS/MORTGAGORS: (1) M/s. Alalika (erstwhile M/s. East West Garments), Proprietor: Mr. Perithambal Hussain Ibrahim, 13, 4th Avenue, River View Colony, Anna Nagar, Chennai - 600 040. (2) Mr. Perithambal Hussain Ibrahim, (Proprietor/Mortgagor), S/o Late Ahmed Ibrahim, No. 2/96, Govindnagar, 2nd Street, Moulaye Sarai, Chennai - 600 122. Also at: St. Nivas Apartments, 1 Block, 1st Main Road, Door No. 21, Flat No. 4, Anna Nagar East, Chennai - 600 102. (3) Mr. K. Asik Ibrahim, (Guarantor), S/o Perithambal Hussain Ibrahim, Door No. 408, Seethakathi Street, Rajapalayam - 626 117. (Branch Name: Indian Bank, Mogappair Branch (now transferred to SAM Branch, Chennai)). TOTAL AMOUNT DUE TO THE BANKS ON 28.07.2026: Rs. 3,08,08,650.52 (Rupees Three crores eight lakhs twenty two thousand six hundred fifty and paise fifty two only) with further interest from 29.07.2026, other charges and expenses thereon.

3. NAME AND ADDRESS OF THE BORROWERS/GUARANTORS/MORTGAGORS: (1) M/s. Hitro Energy Solutions, New No. 784, Old No. 426, Anna Salai, Nandanam, Chennai - 600 035. (2) Mr. N.S. Rangachari, (Proprietor), S/o Sundaravandhan, No. 2, Athiyala No. 13, 13th Avenue I Street, East Abiramapuram, Chennai - 600 018. (3) Mrs. Nirmala Rangachari, (Director/Guarantor/Mortgagor), W/o Mr. N.S. Rangachari, No. 2, Athiyala No. 13, 13th Avenue I Street, East Abiramapuram, Chennai - 600 018. (4) M/s. Hitro Energy Solutions Pvt. Ltd., New No. 784, Old No. 426, Anna Salai, Nandanam, Chennai - 600 035. Also at: No. 29/12, M.K.A. Kovil Street, Mylapore, Chennai - 600 004. (5) Mr. N.S. Rangachari, (Director/Guarantor/Mortgagor), S/o Sundaravandhan, No. 2, Athiyala No. 13, 13th Avenue I Street, East Abiramapuram, Chennai - 600 018. (6) Mrs. Nirmala Rangachari, (Director/Guarantor/Mortgagor), W/o Mr. N.S. Rangachari, No. 2, Athiyala No. 13, 13th Avenue I Street, East Abiramapuram, Chennai - 600 018. (Branch Name: Indian Bank, Mylapore Branch (now transferred to SAM Branch, Chennai)). TOTAL AMOUNT DUE TO THE BANKS ON 28.07.2026: Rs. 5,52,94,108.86 (Rupees Five crores fifty two lakhs ninety four thousand one hundred eight and paise eighty six only) with further interest from 29.07.2026, other charges and expenses thereon.

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missing climbers. Purja's expedition company called his death an immeasurable loss to the mountaineering world, praising his courage, humility and inspirational leadership.

Hindu leader Chinmoy Das gets bail in 2 cases

DHAKA: AA High Court on Sunday granted jailed Hindu rights leader Chinmoy Krishna Das bail in two cases, but he will remain in prison on four other cases, including treason and murder, are still pending, his lawyer said. Das was arrested in November 2024 on sedition charges, triggering protests and communal tensions. India had expressed concern over his arrest and urged authorities to ensure the safety of minorities. His lawyers have repeatedly sought bail, citing his prolonged detention and ill health.

Kanchipuram District-53102, hereby declare that V. SATHIYANARAYAN, SATYANARAYAN and surname VENKATESAN SATYANARAYAN appearing in my various documents are one and the same person as myself. Henceforth, I shall be known as V. SATHIYANARAYAN for all purposes.

2. Last date for submission of EMD: 07.08.2026 upto 05:00 PM. For online registration and further technical support please contact Service providers Mobile No: 7337445545 / 6300339690 / 7337445546 / 9912756216 For further details please contact: Ph: 728879806, and 728879829 UPR K.G.No.38/PV/C-AG/NC/06/2026 Dt.08.08.2026 Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR

Quote/Express TRY TO LEAVE THE EARTH A BETTER PLACE THAN WHEN YOU ARRIVED

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA-DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC -SHAR SRIHARIKOTA-524124

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE

e-Tender Notice No. 1) SHAR/CMD/IE/2687206/2025-27 Date: 29/07/2026
2) SHAR/CMD/IE/2687206/2025-27 Date: 29/07/2026

On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following works:

Sl. No.	Name of work	Value
1	Construction of new water treatment plant with OHT (GLR+OHT, Pump house, Filtration room, etc.) at SMPCC Unit-2, SDSC SHAR.	\$2.53 Lakhs
2	Augmentation of Fire water pump house with GLR (Construction of 825 Cum GLR & Pump House) at SMPCC Unit-4, SDSC SHAR.	94.53 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) up to 17/08/2026, 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bidding (tender) notice inviting tenders (NIT) on the website: <https://www.saro.gov.in/tenders.html> and tender free view at: <https://www.tenderindia.gov.in>

Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

Property 2 - Mortgage Property owned by Mrs. Nirmala Rangachari: Item No. 1 - Plot No. 456: All the piece and parcel of the vacant land situated in No. 107, Nemli Village, Chengalpattu Taluk, Kanchipuram Dist. forming part of the layout known as Royal Majestic Compound bearing Plot No. 456 measuring an extent of 2400 Sq. ft. Comprised in Survey No. 210374 (Part) in No. 107, Nemli Village. And situated within the Registration District of Chengalpattu and Sub Registration District of Tiruppur. Item No. 2 - Plot No. 367: All the piece and parcel of the vacant land situated in No. 107, Nemli Village, Chengalpattu Taluk, Kanchipuram Dist. forming part of the layout known as Royal Majestic Compound bearing Plot No. 367 measuring an extent of 2400 Sq. ft. Comprised in Survey No. 21036C (Part) and 21341A (Part) in No. 107, Nemli Village. And situated within the Registration District of Chengalpattu and Sub Registration District of Tiruppur. Prior Encumbrance known to the Bank: Not known. TYPE OF POSSESSION: Symmetric.

RESERVE PRICE: Rs. 32.00 Lakhs	Bid Increment: Rs. 50,000/-	PROPERTY ID No.: ID1049054914078	EMD: Rs. 3.20 Lakhs
BANK WEBSITE	E-AUCTION WEBSITE	SALE NOTICE	PROPERTY LOCATION
DATE AND TIME OF E-AUCTION: 03.09.2026 FROM 11.00 A.M. TO 4.00 P.M.			
Last Date for submission of Tender form/EMD: 03.09.2026			

Bidders are advised to visit the website (<https://www.banknet.in>) of our e auction service provider PNB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. to participate in online bid. For Technical Assistance Please call PNB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. Helpline No. 8291222222, email ID: support.banknet@pnballiance.com and other help line numbers available in service providers help desk. For Registration status with PNB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. and EMD Status, please contact support.banknet@pnballiance.com. For property details and photograph of the property and auction terms and conditions please visit: <https://www.banknet.in> and for clarifications related to this portal please contact Helpline No. 8291222222. Bidders are advised to use Property ID Number mentioned above while searching for the property in the website with <https://www.banknet.in>

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Place: Chennai

AUTHORISED OFFICER, INDIAN BANK.

Profit booking in AI stocks lifts Indian mkt

After months of selling, FIIs turn net buyers in July, aided by moderate valuations, improved corporate earnings

ARSHAD KHAN @ New Delhi

IN what appears to be a tailwind for the domestic equity market, the recent correction and heightened volatility in AI and semiconductor-driven markets such as the US, Taiwan, South Korea and Japan are prompting global investors to reassess steep valuations and rotate capital towards relatively better-valued markets like India.

After being underperforming for the majority of the last 22 months, domestic equity benchmarks - BSE Sensex and NSE Nifty - outperformed tech-heavy global indices by gaining about 2% in July. After months of heavy selling, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) turned net buyers in July with a cumulative purchase worth ₹20199 crore, aided by

moderating valuations, an improving corporate earnings outlook and stable currency.

Analysts believe the pull-back in global technology stocks is more of a profit-booking phase than the end of the rally, but it has nevertheless reduced the intensity of FII selling in India, with investors increasingly favouring sectors like financials, healthcare, industrials and IT services that offer stronger earnings visibility and a more attractive risk-reward profile. Perwez Azeem, joint CEO, Anand Rathi Wealth Limited, said uncertainties in other Asian markets like Taiwan and South Korea have prompted a reallocation of foreign capital towards relatively stronger emerging markets like India. "The return of FII flows is a positive signal for market sen-



timent and liquidity, and can support equity markets in the near term. However, over the longer term, sustained market performance will continue to depend on corporate earnings and economic fundamentals rather than capital flows alone," added Azeem. Sunny Agrawal, head - fundamental research, SBI Securities, said global investors are taking profits in AI and semiconductor-heavy markets like Taiwan, South Korea and parts

of the US after an extraordinary rally as concerns over rich valuations, earnings sustainability and massive capex being undertaken by hyperscalers have prompted investors to diversify.

"After a rally, it is more likely to be a profit booking. Steep correction is due to entry of retail trades through leveraged ETFs which are forced to rebalance the heavily concentrated portfolio almost on daily basis due to sharp movement in the stocks like Samsung. Going forward, AI investment cycle and demand supply will determine whether exponential earnings growth is sustainable and that will be the key determinant of sustenance of strong upmove witnessed during last 2 years," said Agrawal.

ment, social, and governance (ESG) preferences by Gen X (those in their 40s and 50s) compared to the boomer generation (those in their 60s and 70s). The young are even more assertive about ESG. If wealth passes further down the generations to millennials (30-40s) and Gen Z (late teens or 20s), investors among them want to influence corporate ESG decisions even more, the survey observed.

MONEY-WISE

CHILDREN CAN'T BE RETIREMENT PLAN



PVSUBRAMANYAM writes at www.subramoney.com and has authored the best seller *Retire Rich - Invest ₹40 a day*

IN traditional Indian society, children - especially sons - were expected to be the primary "retirement plan" for parents. This worked in the era of joint families, where multiple generations lived together, incomes were pooled, and caregiving was shared. Today, this model is becoming difficult and unreliable for most middle-class families.

Here's why:

- **Nuclear Families and Geographic Separation** Urbanisation, better job opportunities, and education have led to the breakdown of the joint family system. Children often move to other cities or abroad for work. Many elderly now live alone or with their spouse. Even when children want to help, providing daily care, emotional support, or quick financial help becomes logistically hard when they live far away.
- **Smaller Families = Fewer**

Today's middle-aged adults (roughly 35-55) are often financially supporting both their ageing parents and their own children's education, weddings, and housing. This is called the sandwich generation.

They face:

- High EMIs on home loans and car loans
- Rising cost of their own children's education (especially if abroad)
- Their own retirement savings goals
- Medical expenses

In many middle-class households earning ₹1-1.5 lakh per month, after basic expenses and EMIs, there is very little left to support parents without compromising their own future.

- **Longer Lifespans + Skyrocketing Healthcare Costs** People are living much longer (retirement can now last 30+ years). At the same time, medical inflation in India is 12-14% per year. A single major illness or surgery can cost several lakhs. One child's salary often can't sustainably cover high medical costs for two parents over many years while managing their own family needs.
- **Changing Social and Economic Realities** Rising individualism: Younger generations are more focused on their careers, lifestyle, and their own children's future.
- **Dual-income households:** Both husband and wife work, leaving less time for caregiving.

MONEY MATTERS

GEN Z AND THE GREAT WEALTH TRANSFER EFFECT

THE young and restless in India are displaying their state of mind. Recent protests against corruption in the conduct of competitive exams and the fallout show the young in India are not to be taken for granted by the old. As they gain experience and wealth, youngsters will get assertive and want to be heard.

From this column's perspective, their attitude towards wealth will determine the future of wealth outcomes. As per the World Economic Forum, a Switzerland-based think tank, \$89 trillion of worldwide wealth transfer is slated to happen over the next decade in countries like the US, the UK, Japan, and Europe. Nearly \$1.5 trillion (₹140 lakh cr) would be transferred in generational wealth in India over the next decade, as per a report published by EY India, a global consulting firm, along with Julius Baer India, an investment bank.

A new survey by Bank of America of the rich in the US shows, for the first time, inherited business ownership has crossed purchased ownership. Turning into a venture capital fund manager attracts more young people in rich households than expanding traditional family business. Family offices are created mainly by entrepreneurs who built successful companies and want to give structure to their wealth plan. On a smaller scale in a regular household, succession plan-



FINANCIAL KNOWLEDGE
RAJAS KELKAR (The author is editor-in-chief at www.moneyminutes.in)

managed. The traditional asset allocation or wealth management rule of thumb is to follow 60:40 split between equity and fixed-income assets. The Bank of America survey finds future generations are looking beyond that and into private markets and alternative investments. These could be private equity, venture capital, commercial realty or crypto assets.

Another area of interest for the next generation is longevity. We have seen reports of entrepreneurs using hormone therapies themselves or investing in businesses that create products or services for a long life. The World Economic Forum survey published late in 2025 observed a marked rise in reported environ-

mental, social, and governance (ESG) preferences by Gen X (those in their 40s and 50s) compared to the boomer generation (those in their 60s and 70s).

The young are even more assertive about ESG. If wealth passes further down the generations to millennials (30-40s) and Gen Z (late teens or 20s), investors among them want to influence corporate ESG decisions even more, the survey observed.

In India too, things may not be different among those who know they will inherit wealth. Their appetite for risk to invest in alternative assets is much more than previous generations. That is already influencing the way financial services providers offer services to you. Banks are intensifying their focus on engaging you via relationship managers to move beyond deposits and offer other financial products like investment trusts, commodities and real estate.

Wealth management firms are cropping up in major cities across India. Regulated Portfolio Management Services (PMS) are attracting more rich households than ever before. With AI to support, wealth advisory need not be a privilege of the few. You may easily combine an independent financial advisor with

IN CONVERSATION



VENKATRAMAN NARAYANAN
Managing director, Happiest Minds



JOSEPH ANANTHARAJU
Co-chairman & chief executive officer, Happiest Minds

'Hirings are becoming more specific to skills required, project type'

APPIEST Minds co-chairman & chief executive officer Joseph Anantharaju and MD Venkatraman Narayanan discuss how enterprise AI adoption is evolving in an interview with *TNIE's Padmini Dhruvaraj*. They also talk about growing demand for AI talent optimisation, AI consulting and implementation projects, changes in hiring and workforce training, and the company's growth outlook the rest of the financial year. **Edited Excerpts:**

Why is AI token optimisation becoming important for enterprises?

Joseph Anantharaju: Token utilisation has become a much bigger conversation over the last month or month-and-a-half. Some of our customers who were early adopters of AI have come back to us asking us to benchmark their usage and find ways to optimise token consumption. In one case, we were able to reduce token consumption by 75%. We have developed best practices and guidelines based on that experience. Where customers use our productivity platform, we are embedding these practices into the platform. For others, we help them optimise using those best practices.

Is AI spending coming from fresh budgets or from existing technology spending?

Joseph Anantharaju: It is a mixture of both. Some customers have allocated fresh budgets for AI initiatives. Others are optimising the run part of their business using AI and productivity tools, and then using those savings to fund AI projects. If they don't have a separate AI budget, or if they have exhausted it, they are looking at ways to optimise spending to create room for AI.

Are AI consulting projects generating more business for Happiest Minds?

Joseph Anantharaju: We don't report consulting revenue separately for AI, but these engagements generally have better margins as the billing rates are higher. In most cases, once we complete consulting engagement and proof of concept, we get the follow-up implementation project. There have been a few cases where customers have implemented it internally, but in most cases consulting engagement leads to larger implementation work.

When will Happiest Minds begin reporting AI-led revenue?

Venkatraman Narayanan: We already have the number, but we want to stress-test it before we publish it. Once we disclose it, it is something we will continue reporting. AI-led revenue is already a decent-sized business for us and it is only growing. We expect to start publishing that number in the coming quarters.

Has AI changed the way Happiest Minds hires?

Joseph Anantharaju: We are seeing productivity improvements and less effort is required to deliver the same amount of work. At the same time, customers are asking us to do more work, including projects that were on their wish list earlier. Hiring has become much more dynamic. Instead of hiring first and deploying later, recruitment is becoming more specific to the skills required.

Venkatraman Narayanan: Hiring has three parts - replace-

Some customers have allocated fresh budgets for AI initiatives. Others are optimising their business using AI and productivity tools, and then using those savings to fund AI projects. If they don't have a separate AI budget, they are looking at ways to optimise spending to create room for AI

People to Share the Responsibility
India's fertility rate has fallen to about 2.0. Families are smaller — many couples now have one or two children instead of four or five. With fewer children, the financial and caregiving load on each child increases significantly.
● **The "Sandwich Generation" Squeeze**

● **Economic pressure on youth:** Many young professionals carry student loans, face job instability (especially in the gig economy), or have high aspirations. While most children still want to support their parents, many simply cannot do so adequately without significant personal sacrifice.
● **Legal Protection Exists but Is Not Reliable.**

ning could be a registered will or a family agreement. Some other affluent families create trust funds to ensure a smooth transfer of money to the next generation.
As wealth moves from people in their 70s and 80s to people in their 30s and 40s, there will be a change in how money is



an AI tool.
Building your understanding of protecting wealth, growing it steadily, and then passing it on peacefully to your successors seems like a straightforward process. However, it requires you to up your knowledge game. Investing without goals or waiting too long can diminish the wealth effect.

ment hiring, hiring for new positions and hiring for the future. For future demand, our focus is on training the existing workforce via internal programmes to make them AI-ready, while bringing in people with AI skills when there is fresh demand. We are not hiring people first and then deciding where to deploy them.

Are AI projects leading to business for Happiest Minds?
Joseph Anantharaju: At the company level, 94.95% of our business is repeat business. We don't separately track whether AI engagements directly generate more AI work, but it is likely to lead to additional business, including follow-on implementation and related opportunities.

Analysts see rate pause despite inflation

BEN KOCHEVEDAN @Mumbai

MAJORITY of the Mint Road observers are of the view that the Reserve Bank-led monetary policy committee that begins its three-day customary meeting from Monday to decide on the third monetary policy review of the fiscal, to pause again both on key rates, as well as on policy stance fronts.

The policy review comes after three years of a major shift in monetary policy strategy — from aggressive inflation control following post-pandemic surge in prices to a more balanced approach aimed at supporting growth while maintaining macroeconomic stability. Soumyakanti Ghosh of SBI Research was for status-quo citing a slew of factors like the improving dollar inflows/rising foreign reserves and resultant fall in open forward position of the



Nuvama, Goldman Sachs predict status quo

Foreign brokerages Nuvama and Goldman Sachs both have held views as domestic growth remains stronger than expected and inflation has eased from recent peaks, but acknowledge that there are persistent risks stemming from global commodity markets, geopolitical tension and weather-related disruptions warrant a cautious approach

RBI in forex market, better-than-expected monsoons leading better sowing, a strengthening rupee and Q1 growth climbing 7% among others.
"The RBI is mostly to pause (rates) even as global risks rise

but domestically there are many positives like Q1 growth likely to surpass 7%; \$35 billion capital inflows till July-end, enabling foreign exchange recoup of \$12.5 billion as of July 24 and vacating outstanding

forward position by \$13 billion in short-end till June. But the current backdrop has made soft language costlier: oil volatility, rupee pressure, external-flow caution and higher inflation projections make an explicitly dovish message less likely."

From macro front, monsoons have recovered with July surplus reducing overall nationwide shortfall to 13%, he said, adding reservoir levels are equal to normal (though less than last year level), kharif sowing is 4.7% lower than the 2025 levels indicating better harvest. Ica Ratings chief economist Aditi Nayyar expects a hold on rates and policy stance. "So far, there is no evidence of generalisation of inflationary pressures, suggesting a likely status quo on August 5. Greater clarity is also needed on monsoons turnout," Nayyar told TNIE.

Govt prepares Cabinet note to amend definition of services under SEZ Act

PUSHPITA DEY @New Delhi

THE Department of Commerce has prepared a cabinet note to propose some amendments in the definition of services under the Special Economic Zones (SEZ) Act, with a special focus on Engineer-to-Zero (EZ) services, said sources aware of the matter.

As per government officials, it has been proposed to broaden definition of services under the SEZ Act and accordingly align it to the Goods and Services Tax (GST) framework and remove long-standing requirement that the payment for service exports from SEZ units be done via foreign currency.

"The Cabinet note has been prepared proposing the amendments in definition of services under SEZ Act. We are hoping



AMENDMENTS

- 1 Commerce ministry proposed to broaden definition of services
- 2 Aim is to align it to GST norm, remove need for foreign currency payment

soon the changes will be made in the Act, once it goes to the Parliament," said the official. The proposed amendment

would modify existing provision that mandates payment for services in foreign currency. Once the amendments are approved, service firms operating in SEZs would be allowed to receive payments in rupees for services supplied to entities in the Domestic Tariff Area (DTA), a government official had previously told TNIE.

This move comes amid broader effort by the government to revive attractiveness of SEZs for service companies, particularly IT and business services firms. Industry representatives from SEZ have been reaching out to the Centre requesting it to make the changes as they argued the foreign exchange requirement is incompatible with expanding domestic digital economy, where SEZ-based firms cater to Indian clients.



SPORT

'Why so much jersey discussion before WC?'



Former goalkeeper PR Sreejesh has advised the Indian men's hockey team to leave behind the unnecessary jersey controversy but questioned the timing of the change. "Why is there so much discussion before the World Cup (beginning from August 15) is it because of the saffron colour or simply because the colour changed?" he said.

newindianexpress.com

SIX

From Tejaswin Shankar's narrative-shaping decathlon bronze to Gulveer Singh's brace of medals, more than a few Indian athletes had a Games to savour. A look at six of them...

Sakshi Chaudhary

Women's 51kg boxing | Gold

You could argue her biggest competition happened even before getting to Glasgow. At the trials in India, she beat Nikhat Zareen. In Glasgow, it was plain sailing for the 25-year-old. Inside the ring, she dominated her opponents in each of her four bouts as she enjoyed dominating unanimous wins. Up next for the Bhiwani pugilist? A tilt at history at the Asiad.



Tejaswin Shankar

Decathlon | Bronze

India's Iron Man of these Games, he finally has a major multi-discipline medal. An Indian pioneer in every sense of the word, he pushed his body to the absolute limit in the hardest event to come away with bronze a few days after a knee flare up. To see him go toe to toe with Damian Warner who had won gold in Tokyo in 2021 was surreal. The 27-year-old is just getting started.

Gulveer Singh

Men's 5000m | Bronze & 10,000m | Silver

The endurance athlete broke records with his double in the space of a few nights. He showed his capacity to stay with some of the best athletes at this level before coming into his own in the final lap. If he can continue this form to the Asian Games, he will fancy his chances of medalling again in one of the most gruelling disciplines.

M Sreesankar

Men's long jump | Silver

For an athlete, any long-term injury to the knee can have devastating consequences. It's why Sreesankar's second placed finish was worthy of a celebration post his patellar injury in 2024. Those consistent and explosive 8m jumps will follow at bigger events but do not underestimate the importance of what this will do to him in terms of confidence.



(From L) The gold medal winners Mirabai Chanu (weightlifting), Asmita Dey (judo) and Sakshi Chaudhary (boxing) | PTI

AFTER GLASGOW HIGH, INDIA EYE HOME RUN

Despite key sports missing, athletes surpass expectations to finish 4th

FIROZ MIRZA @Chennai

WITH two of its most successful disciplines — shooting (sport was not there in 2022 as well) and wrestling — not part of the 2026 edition, replicating the Birmingham show looked difficult for India as the truncated Commonwealth Games began in Glasgow on July 23. Ten days later, the country's athletes surpassed all expectations as India retained the fourth-place finish on the medal tally.

Given the way they performed in Scotland, India can eye to match their best show, second-place finish at the 2010 Delhi Games, or even go one better when they host the quadrennial multi-sport event in Ahmedabad in 2030.

Since their debut at the CWG back in 1934, India have featured in all but four editions (1930, 1950, 1962 and 1986). Across all the Games before the latest one, shooting and wrestling contributed the most to India's medal tally with the first discipline delivering 135 medals including 63 gold while the latter one producing 115 medals including 49 gold. Weightlifting is third on the list. Besides, there are sports like badminton and table tennis, which have been major contributors but were missing. It didn't matter in Glasgow as the coun-

couldn't finish on top of the podium but Tejaswin Shankar became the first Indian to medal (bronze) in decathlon while Gulveer Singh bagged first-ever long distance medals (silver in 10,000m and bronze in 5,000m) at this quadrennial event.

"The judokas have performed really well and created history," Mukesh Kumar, interim president of the Judo Federation of India, told this daily. Kumar looked optimistic for a better show in the next edition as it is going to be hosted by the country. "Now that the next CWG is in India, we will start preparing for it from now. We will meet and submit our proposal for the next CWG," he said. One athlete, who has been a regular on the podium since 2014 is ace weightlifter Mirabai Chanu, and she deservedly completed a hat-trick of gold in Glasgow becoming the first woman lifter to do so. Mirabai's gold, however, was the lone in the discipline but head coach Vijay Sharma held the performance good. "In a few weight categories, we lost the gold by barest of the margins but eight out of 11 finishing on the podium is a good sign. The campaign was as per our expectations," Sharma said.

Women power

Eight of India's 13 gold have

highlight the big transformation in Indian sport.

"Seeing India's women win eight of our 13 gold medals fills me with immense pride," PT Usha, Indian Olympic Association president and a pioneer herself, said in a press statement. "These achievements are the result of years of dedication by the athletes, their families, coaches and support teams. Every medal tells the story of perseverance and sacrifice. That is the true spirit of Nari Shakti."

Return of wrestling, shooting

As India is set to host the next edition, sports like wrestling and shooting are expected to be back when Ahmedabad welcomes athletes from across the globe. The return of these disciplines will only see a rise in India's medal tally. "Wrestlers won 12 medals including six gold in the last edition. Usually, the Games have men's freestyle and women wrestling but as we are hosting the event in 2030, the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) is trying to include Greco-Roman as well. The federation has already spoken to the United World Wrestling and the organising committee," said WFI president Sanjay Kumar Singh. With Glasgow handing over the baton and CWG flag to India

Adille pleased with progress

INDRANEEL DAS @Chennai

DAYS before the Commonwealth Games began, there were expectations on India but not as much as the medals tally reflected on Sunday. Among all the bright spots in Glasgow, one that glowed most was athletics. It was poetic that Gulveer Singh rounded off India's campaign with a bronze — his second at the event. No Indian has ever done it before.

This reflected India's performance at these Games. Adille Sumariwalla, Athletics Federation of India spokesperson, was excited because of India's chances at the next Games. Speaking to this daily while on his way back and transiting in London, Sumariwalla said India have performed exceptionally well. "This has been the best performance outside India," the former AFI president said. "From three medals in Glasgow (2014) to three in Gold Coast, eight in Birmingham to 10 in Glasgow. There has been an upward trend."

However, Sumariwalla said that this was more like a stepping stone towards the Asian Games next month. "This event, we were not really using as the final event because our final focus is Asian Games," he said. "We are looking to do well at the Asiad. Again, if you look at events, we have got two medals in certain events, which show the bench strength that we have. Look at javelin, triple jump, 5000-10000m or long jump. If you look at all those events, it really shows that you have enough bench strength. If TJ's (Tejaswin Shankar) knee had not gone bad, we might have had two medals in high jump also." Sumariwalla believed



(Top) Gulveer Singh after winning bronze in 5000m; Neeraj Chopra | XPN

that India have improved on track. He felt that the results are part of the process. "Sometimes track events do better and sometimes field. Like last time, we had two medals in (race)walk. Now, we got two in 5000m-10,000m. We had a medal in steeplechase, and this time a medal in decathlon. These things will keep happening."

He also praised M Sreesankar and Praveen Chithravar for their medals, too. "Neeraj Chopra has made an exceptional comeback and will do better as he improves his fitness," he said. "I think exciting times are ahead of us. I am also extremely pleased to see Neeraj make a comeback with 86m (85.83m) in those windy conditions. I think it was a very good comeback from his injury," he added.

Asiad for us is like the Olympics: BFI chief

ANMOL GURUNG @Chennai

SATURDAY was a red-letter day for Indian boxing. As many as seven boxers from the country returned with gold medals around their necks while three

teraction facilitated by BFI. Singh, who watched the boxers make history from up close at Glasgow, felt the upcoming Asiad, scheduled to be from September 19 to October 4 in Japan, will be sort of a marker

Asmita Dev
Women's -48kg Judo | Gold
India has had success at multiple combat sports at this level but never in judo. Asmita Dev changed it with her history-shattering gold to go to a place no Indian judoka had ever gone before. It was the start of an unprecedented medal haul across both judo and boxing. That she won gold during the Golden Score (sudden-death) spoke about how she handled pressure.



Sharmila Dhankar
Women's shot put F57 | Gold
She came into the event as the para-athlete to beat and she proved it. All of her six throws were better than the athlete who won silver. Her story, of course, is also a story of perseverance and grit as she had been in an abusive marriage before walking out. Now, the 39-year-old stands as proof of India's successful para-athlete programme.

try's boxers came up with their best-ever show winning 10 medals including seven gold and judoka creating history clinching two gold, a silver and a bronze. Track and field athletes

been won by the women athletes. Be it Mirabai or para-athlete Sharmila Dhankar or judoka Asmita Dev or boxer Sakshi Chaudhary, all of them produced a remarkable show to

at the Closing Ceremony, Indian athletes have four years to get themselves ready and come up with their best-ever show in the event. Over to Amdavad.
Full story: newindianexpress.com

(Cyrus) in men's -100kg rd of 16; Y Ghanghas lost to J Whitehouse (Wales) in men's +100kg; I Narang lost to N Wood in women's -78kg.

won silver, the country's best-ever show in the history of Commonwealth Games by a country mile. The Boxing Federation of India (BFI) president, Ajay Singh, is also a delighted man. But he's also mindful that the boxers' task is far from over as the Asian Games — expected to be much more challenging than the CWG — is not far away.



Ajay Singh

ahead of their ultimate target — the Los Angeles Games. "The Asian Games for us is like the Olympics. The best teams in the world today are Asian teams. The top three teams in the world today are Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and India. "In addition to that, there's a strong Chinese contingent. This performance cannot be replicated but we'll still do very well. If you win a large number of medals at the Asian Games, you can also be sure you will win medals at the Olympics. We had some good teams here," he said.

Full story: newindianexpress.com

Boxing champions reflect after record punches

ANMOL GURUNG @ Chennai

EACH and every pugilist in the Indian contingent, with their own compelling narratives, had entered the CWG in Glasgow with plenty of grit and purpose. And that was visible during the competition as the boxers, showing their all-round qualities inside the ring, returned with a dream haul of 10 medals (an impressive seven gold and three silver) during the campaign.

It's a return that will echo for long. It was a performance that's uplifting for each one of them and Indian boxing on the whole. Take the case of Arundhati Choudhary, one of the seven gold winners. The talented

pugilist was not just fighting for herself but she was also representing her family — her father was fasting with hope that she could find success — and her home state of Rajasthan.

"My elder sister told me that dad was 'fasting for you'. This was my second Games after the Asian in 2023. I hadn't performed well then and I had to do well in this competition. Also given that I was the first boxer from Rajasthan (to represent India at CWG), I had to do it anyhow," Arundhati, who battled fever in the build-up to her final bout, said.

Sakshi Chaudhary, meanwhile, was looking to make the 51kg category her own after countless toils in the past. Sim-

MEDAL OF HONOUR

- Gold: Preeti Sai Pawar (W54kg)
- Gold: Jasmin Lamborn (W51kg)
- Gold: Sakshi Chaudhary (W51kg)
- Gold: Priya Ghanghas (W60kg)
- Gold: Arundhati Choudhary (W70kg)
- Gold: Sachin Swath (M60kg)
- Gold: Ankur Panghal (M60kg)
- Silver: Jadhav Singh (W51kg)
- Silver: Lovina Borghani (75kg)
- Silver: Narendra Bernal (90+kg)

ilarly, Preeti Sai Pawar, armed with her paint brush and artsy tools apart from her boxing nous, had entered the UK shores with similar determination to cement her status as India's No 1 in her weight category after health concerns, which had kept her away for a long time post Olympics. Sakshi said

beating top-class boxers — Nikhat Zareen and Minakshi Hooda — recently during the national trials had handed her the momentum.

"I was carrying that experience along with me. It became easier to handle pressure. The 51kg weight category is quite competitive in the country and because of that we're able to do well when we go for international competitions," the former junior and world champ said. While Sakshi and Arundhati were first-timers, Jasmin Lamborn was taking part in the quadrennial event for the second time. Jasmin has been operating at a cut above since the start of 2025 season and it was not surprising to see her keep up her green run.

Full story: newindianexpress.com

Spinner Jishnu bowls Thiruvallur to big win

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE

LEFT-ARM spinner S Jishnu's 7/5 helped Thiruvallur hammer Mayiladuthurai by 240 runs in round 1 of the TNCA Inter Districts Under-14 tournament.

Brief scores: Thiruvallur 294/6 (D Prasad-han 90) bt Mayiladuthurai 54 (S Jishnu 7/5); Kanyakumari 176 bt Perambalur 52; Theni 171 bt Salem 166; Villupuram 106/9 lost to Dinakari 107/9 (S Nageshwaran 4/8); Krishnagiri 265 (F Umair Akbar 106) bt Virudhunagar 134 (R Kalaiselvan 5/16); Nagapattinam 106 (AG Lingesh 4/33) lost to Ariyalur 107/1; Namakkal 254/5 (K Santhosh 92) bt Sivagangai 52 (R Naren Mithran 5/36); Thiruvallur 123 (Sanjith Kannan 4/15) lost to Cuddalore 124/9; Madurai 294/7 (S Ashwath 50 n.o.)



S Jishnu
bt Pudukkottai 31 (N Harsha Sabarish 5/5); Tirupur 170/9 bt Dharmapuri 98; Ranipet 176 bt Nilgiris 52 in 35 overs (K Harish 4/6); Vellore 133 lost to Tiruchirappalli 134/5; Kallakurichi 74 (J Saathya 5/13) lost to Thanjavur 76/3;

Chengalpattu 191/6 lost to Erode 192/4 (V Anish 69); Kaur 182/4 (V Krishna Nishad 66) bt Tirunelveli 123/9.

'Always special to play TNPL'

Experienced pacer T Natarajan said that the Tamil Nadu Premier League will hold a special place in his heart. "It's because of the TNPL that I got the opportunity to play in the IPL. A massive thanks to the TNCA for this initiative. It has created a wonderful platform for youngsters, especially those from small towns and villages, to showcase their talent. Returning to play here after the IPL brings me immense happiness," Natarajan said after training on Sunday.

Aruthran shines

Young Aruthran Prabhu from Kumaraburam wrote his own script with a brilliant performance in the Mini U10 class as the fourth round of the IAME India Series Karting organised by the Madras Motor Sports Club at the Madras International Karting Arena (MIKA), concluded on Sunday. The gold medalist at the FIA-Asia Pacific Motorsports Championship in Sri Lanka last year, topped the official practice, Heat, Super Heat and the Finals race in his class to finish his campaign this weekend on a high.

Jamshedpur's ISL exit a punch in gut: Chhetri

BENGALURU: Indian football legend Sunil Chhetri has expressed his anguish over Indian Super League side Jamshedpur FC's decision to pull out of the upcoming season, describing the development as "a punch in the gut." Jamshedpur FC had announced their withdrawal from the ISL on July 31 just hours after missing the deadline for payment of participation fee for the upcoming season, beginning September 4.

Commonwealth TT: Indians bag titles

NEW DELHI: Ankur Bhattacharjee and Yashaswini Ghorpade clinched the men's and women's singles title at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships on Sunday. Bhattacharjee emerged a deserving 4-3 winner over Poyas Jain after a hard-fought match. In the women's final, Ghorpade dominated Sreeja Akula to win 4-1.

Taipei Open: Tani claims maiden title

TAIPEI: Seventeen-year-old Tani Sharma claimed her maiden BWF Super 300 title and etched her name into the history books as the youngest player across any category to win the Taipei Open on Sunday. He delivered a commanding 21-16, 21-16 victory over Vietnam's sixth seed Nguyen Thuy Linh in the women's singles final.

Injured Bumrah to miss SL Test series

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE

WITH less than two weeks to go for the first Test in Sri Lanka, India might have been handed a huge blow with Jasprit Bumrah's fitness. Though there is no official word on Bumrah's availability for the entirety of the tour, he is set to miss the red-ball series for India. The Shubman Gill-led and Gautam Gambhir-coached side is under pressure to win both matches in the Island nation to keep their World Test Championship hopes alive. And for that, Bumrah was going to be crucial, especially with the ties to be played with Kookaburra ball.

THE NEW
INDIAN EXPRESS
CHENNAI, MONDAY
03.08.2026

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ANGELA MARY THOMAS

HERE was a time when students in our country progressed from primary school to university in a system where the ability to recall and reproduce information, often without departing from textbook language, mattered more than curiosity or independent thought.

Today, academic frameworks and curricula place greater emphasis on internationally recognised pedagogical approaches centred on inquiry, collaboration, and application, with case study-based and competency-based learning now integral to classroom practice.

This emphasis can be seen in the way assessment has evolved. CBSE board examinations now include competency-based questions designed to test understanding and application, while PARAKH, the national assessment centre under NCERT, has laid down standards for competency-based assessment.

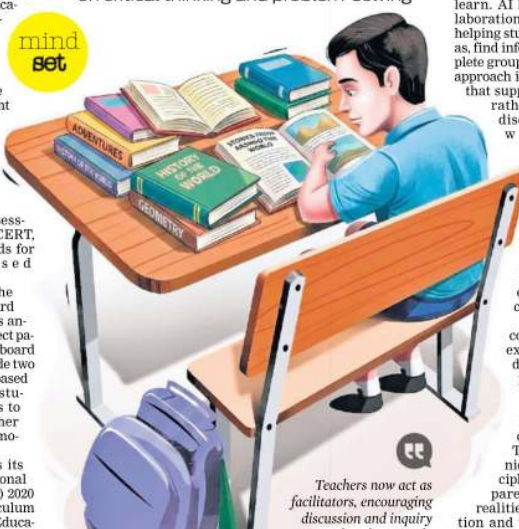
At the state level, the Himachal Pradesh Board of School Education has announced that every subject paper from the March 2027 board examinations will include two compulsory case study-based questions, requiring students to apply concepts to real-life situations rather than rely solely on memorised responses.

This approach draws its direction from the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Educa-

LEARNING THROUGH APPLICATION

With application of concepts in real-life situations at the heart of learning, classrooms are placing greater emphasis on critical thinking and problem-solving

mind set



Teachers now act as facilitators, encouraging discussion and inquiry

orise model responses or assessment patterns, making effective implementation the key factor."

The classroom itself has also changed. Digital platforms, smart boards, online assessments and, more recently, artificial intelligence have expanded the ways students access information, participate in lessons and work together.

"Teachers now act as facilitators, encouraging discussion, inquiry, and application, rather than simply delivering information. This gives students greater scope to engage with and apply what they learn. AI has also made collaboration more efficient by helping students generate ideas, find information, and complete group tasks. But the best approach is to use AI as a tool that supports collaboration rather than replacing discussion and teamwork," says Sengupta.

The emphasis on collaboration also stems from the recognition that learning is inherently social, allowing students to explore ideas collectively. "Collaboration encourages students to exchange ideas, understand different perspectives, and solve problems together, instead of relying solely on individual recall. Teamwork, communication and interdisciplinary thinking prepare students for the realities of higher education and the modern work-



Making room for difference

KARTHIKEYA S

world views

Do students learn ideas of collaboration, tolerance and fraternity in classroom? Or, does it need a 'whole-of-society' approach?

SCHOOLS and colleges are often places where young people encounter diversity for the first time and learn to negotiate differences. Through everyday classroom interactions, they cultivate values such as empathy and mutual respect, while developing the ability to learn, work, and live, alongside people from different backgrounds.

"That is why classrooms play a vital role in nurturing the Constitutional values of equality, fraternity and unity. The education system must reflect the values that the country cherishes," says Abha Dev Habib, Associate Professor in the Department of Physics at Miranda House, Delhi University, and Secretary of the Democratic Teachers' Front. "If these values are given the importance they deserve, classrooms will naturally embody them."

Prof Habib argues that education can help inoculate young people against parochialism, protecting them from radicalisation. Lessons on Indian society, history and structural inequalities, she says, encourage students to understand perspectives beyond their own. She also believes classrooms should not shy away from discussions on politics, identity, religion and other social issues. Such conversations enrich learning, provided they remain respectful and do not encourage unlawful or harmful activities. "At the same time, educational institutions themselves must remain non-partisan and avoid promoting one ideology over another," she notes.

Community classrooms

Academic knowledge assumes new dimensions through sustained engagement with society and social needs

ARYA VIDYA

WHAT if a university classroom had no walls? Imagine a psychology student working with children with developmental disabilities, or an agriculture student collaborating with farmers to address crop-related challenges. Such examples illustrate how educational institutions can extend learning beyond lectures and examinations by engaging with local communities. This is the essence of service-learning, an educational approach that combines academic study with community service, allowing students to connect what they learn with the needs and expe-

periences of local communities.

For many universities, service-learning is no longer an optional add-on but an integral part of higher education. One such initiative is the Community Disability Management and Rehabilitation Programme (CDMRP), an extension centre of the Department of Psychology at the University of Calicut.

civic talk

"The centre supports children with developmental disabilities through assessment, intervention, and rehabilitation, while providing students with hands-on learning through community engagement," says Haritha PS, a former CDMRP intern at the university.

A similar approach is reflected in the Rural Agricultural Work Experience (RAW) programme, conducted by state agricultural universities and recognised agricultural colleges for final-year agriculture students. The programme places students in rural communities as part of their academic training.

"It allows students to work with farmers in villages, apply their classroom knowledge, and share modern farming techniques that can benefit local communities," says Anuraj PR, Research Scholar at the College of Agriculture, Vellanikkara.

Service-learning changes how universities engage with the communities around them. Local knowledge and needs become part of the educational experience, while institutions can contribute expertise to address issues identified on the ground. The result is a two-way exchange in which both institutions and communities contribute to the learning process for all.

tion (NCF-SE) 2023, which call for a shift from lecture-based instruction and rote memorisation to inquiry-driven learning, placing equal emphasis on how students learn and what they learn.

"Of course, while competency-based learning reduces dependence on rote recall of isolated facts, memorisation still

has a place. Students are now expected to retain concepts and processes rather than reproduce textbook content ver-

rather than simply delivering information
Amartya Sengupta, teacher at Memari Crystal Model School

batim," says Amartya Sengupta, teacher at Memari Crystal Model School. "In many cases, learners still mem-

place," he highlights.

With application-oriented learning central to the classroom today, what students can do with what they know is what counts. Retention remains important, but exploring ideas and working with others effectively are critically important parts of the learning process.

exposed to them through classroom discussions, debates and lessons

Abha Dev Habib, associate professor, Delhi University

For Prof Habib, building inclusive classrooms requires teachers to understand students' varied socio-economic realities. Universal access to quality education must remain a priority and Constitutional values such as scientific temper and open-mindedness should be reinforced across society. "It is not the responsibility of teachers alone," she says. "Creating inclusive citizens requires a collective commitment from schools, governments and society alike."

SAKUNTH KUMAR

THE Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras, the conducting body for GATE 2027, has introduced 'Robotics and Automation' as a new paper, taking the total number of subjects to 33. Over the last three years, Data Science & Artificial Intelligence, Naval Architecture & Marine Engineering, and Robotics & Automation have been added as new subjects.

How is 'Robotics and Automation' different from 'Artificial Intelligence'?

While AI is primarily associated with software and IT, Robotics draws from mechanical, electronics, and software engineering. Reflecting this interdisciplinary nature, the syllabus covers topics from mechatronics, robotics, mechanical engineering, and electronic engineering. Although most students pursue careers in Robotics and Automation after completing a BTech degree, the introduction of a dedicated Robotics paper in an MTech entrance examination like GATE raises questions about its relevance. However, the new paper opens up career opportunities in public sector undertakings (PSUs), research organisations, and the medical sector.

A new paper reflects India's growing need for engineers who can bridge hardware, software and intelligent automation

From AI to Automation GATE Expands into Robotics

According to Dr Siva Skandha, Head of the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at CMR Institute of Technology, Hyderabad, "There is massive scope for robotics in the defence, aerospace and energy sectors, as these industries deploy automated assembly lines and robotic systems. The demand for certified robotics talent in Indian public research and production facili-

There is massive scope for robotics in the defence, aerospace and energy sectors. Demand for surgical robotics has been increasing as well

Dr Siva Skandha, Head of the Department of CSE, CMRIT, Hyderabad



ties has increased. Organisations such as DRDO and ISRO look for candidates with specialised skills in robotics."

Dr Skandha adds that India's push towards high-tech manufacturing, electric mobility and defence indigenisation increasingly relies on automation, and that the industry needs engineers who understand both hardware and intelligence. He also highlights robotics' growing role in healthcare. "The demand for surgical robotics has been steadily increasing. In September 2025, AIIMS Raipur

launched India's first government robotic surgery facility, Devshast, enabling minimally invasive procedures with greater precision and safety."

The centre offers training and research opportunities in robotic-assisted surgery for postgraduate students and resident doctors. Similarly, Government Medical College and Hospital, Nagpur, has established a robotic transplant unit. "Overall, the relevance of robotics in healthcare is growing rapidly, with India aiming to train more robotic surgeons to meet future health-

robo ops

Which institutes offer MTech programmes in Robotics?

IIT Guwahati offers an MTech in Robotics and Artificial Intelligence, although admissions are conducted through the institute's own process rather

than GATE. IIT Hyderabad offers an MTech in Robotics and Intelligent Systems, while IIT Madras offers an interdisciplinary Master's programme in Robotics. Several NITs, including NIT Rourkela, NIT Bhopal, and NIT Tiruchirappalli, have also established robotics research facilities. Among private institutions, SRM University offers an MTech in Robotics, while VIT University offers a related programme in Mechatronics.

Who can opt for the Robotics paper in GATE?

Given its interdisciplinary nature, the Robotics and Automation paper can be chosen by BTech graduates in Electrical Engineering, Mechanical Engineering, Computer Science, Artificial Intelligence, Electronics and Communication Engineering, and Instrumentation Engineering. Third-year BTech students are also eligible to register for the GATE examination.

The paper carries 100 marks, of which 85 marks are allotted to the core subject and 15 marks to General Aptitude. For one-mark multiple-choice questions, one-third of a mark is deducted for every incorrect answer, while two-thirds of a mark is deducted for each incorrect response to a two-mark multiple-choice question.

THINK BIG

Children become confident decision-makers when adults give them room to think

Raising resilient children means balancing emotional support with opportunities to let them make decisions, solve problems and learn independently

YECHURI SASHIKANTH

PARENTS often want two things for their children: the confidence that comes from feeling secure at home, and the independence to think and act for themselves. Educators argue that the

challenge lies not in choosing one over the other, but in creating an environment where both can flourish.

"Education is a process that combines a supportive emotional atmosphere at home and an enabling atmosphere in school," says Nishi Dhanjal, Principal of Dharav High School, Jaipur. "The moment children feel safe, they get curious, which turns learning into an essential part of their lives."

Children are more willing to explore, take intellectual risks, and face academic challenges, when they grow up in an emotionally secure environment.

Simple family rituals like sharing meals, taking evening walks, or making time for regular conversations, help create that sense of security. An environment where mistakes are accepted also prepares children to participate more confidently in school.

"Though emotional security



starts from the very core of family life, it is the school that needs to create the perfect environ-

ment to develop independence. The modern classroom cannot be limited to providing immedi-

Small choices matter

Self-regulation develops through ordinary experiences. Letting children choose, wait, negotiate and live with small consequences can help them manage impulses and emotions daily

ate solutions but needs to stimulate proper questioning," Dhanjal says. Parents can also reinforce classroom learning through routine activities. Managing weekly pocket money, measuring ingredients while

cooking, researching holiday destinations, or discussing a book or a news event over dinner can encourage children to reason, communicate, and make decisions using situations they encounter in daily life.

Parents and teachers gradually move from directing decisions to offering guidance and encouragement as children grow older. Together, these experiences help children develop the confidence to think independently while remaining emotionally grounded.



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DAY'S DIARY

First of its kind

Christopher Columbus began his first transatlantic voyage on this day in 1492, setting sail from Palos de la Frontera, Spain

ENTERPRISE OF THE INDIES

Financed by two Spanish rulers, King Ferdinand of Aragon and Queen Isabella of Castile, Columbus began his journey with the goal to find a direct western water route to Asia



THE DESTINATION

After a journey of 10 weeks, he reached what is now believed to be Watling Island in the Bahamas, which he named San Salvador



THE DARK SIDE

His arrival signalled the beginning of centuries of colonisation, displacement, and cultural erasure for many European communities

Keeping up with Studio Ghibli

PG 3

Following Friendship Day, CE takes a look at the pros and cons of AI-powered platforms turning into 24/7 'buddies'

CAN FRIENDSHIP



Madurai Panthers ready to rule

ASHOK VENUGOPAL

CONFIDENCE. That is what Madurai Panthers skipper Anirudh Sita Ram and coach KB Arun Karthik are exuding ahead of the Tamil Nadu Premier League (TNPL) that begins on August 4 in Dindigul. Arun, who has played for Madurai in the past and has been part of the title-winning team, will be donning the role as a coach this season. "We have a good team that has the right amount of experience and youth in its ranks. We have a bunch of youngsters who have done well at the U19 level and accustomed to playing like



kabaddi team in the near future. "A lot of foreign companies are watching (IPL and the Indian state leagues) now. The TNPL has been there for 10 years. I think this is the

who can bowl in the powerplay and death like Gurjapneet and Periyasamy. But, we need to put runs on the board and in the next few days we will work on fixing the top order.

BE BOT?

NIDHI VINOD & PARVANA K B

"One," Aristotle once said, "would choose a friendless existence on condition of having all the other good things in the world."

More than two millennia later, the Greek philosopher's observation still feels current.

The need for companionship has remained constant. What has, however, changed is where people now look for it. Daily life has become a constant race against the clock, leaving little room for conversation. Friends and family may still be only a tap away, yet not always available at the moment someone needs reassurance, advice, or simply a space to think aloud.

Now we have a new kind of companion — an AI chatbot that is always online, and never says, "I will get back later." Ever-ready with advice, suggestions, reassurance, and even an e-shoulder to cry on.

Twenty-three-year-old Theertha does not remember exactly when talking to AI became part of her daily routine. It did not begin with loneliness, nor did she set out looking for a digital friend. At first, the exchanges were practical. She sought help with a college presentation, a birthday message she could not quite word, and an email to a professor.

Then the questions became more frequent and personal.

"Which outfit looks better?" "Does this message sound too harsh?"

"Am I overthinking this?"

"Earlier, I would pose such questions to my friends. Now I ask AI first. It's become an involuntary reliance," she laughs.

Theertha does not call the chatbot a 'friend'. Yet, she admits, it has quietly taken over conversations that once belonged to friends.

The attraction lies in its readiness. It does not seem distracted, impatient, or weighed down by problems of its own. There is no need to wonder whether it is a good time to call, whether one is oversharing, or being silly or shy. A request to rewrite an email can turn into a conversation about workplace stress. A query about a text message can open into doubts about a relationship. And, of course, any dirty secret is considered okay within the chatbox.

What begins as assistance can gradually move into emotional territory, often without the user noticing the transition. Multimedia professional Ammu K has noticed this shift. She increasingly turns to AI for everyday decisions — from choosing a skincare routine to deciding whether an outfit suits an occasion, or getting a second opinion on makeup.

"Everyone is busy with their own lives, and I don't want to keep bothering them over small decisions," she says. "It's also a very private, non-judgemental space. Some-



times I don't even need the perfect answer. I just want a little reassurance. AI is pretty good at pep talk."

She has noted a similar change in her mother's routine as well. "I was surprised. What began as curiosity has become a habit for her. Whether she is looking for a new recipe to try or ideas for home decor, AI is often the first 'adviser' she turns to," Ammu laughs.

At the centre of such 'companionships', notes psychiatrist Dr Amithabh Sajeev, is the feeling of being heard. "Companionships do more than ease loneliness," he explains. "They help regulate stress and strengthen emotional security."

It is this feel-good factor that makes people turn to AI. "When people feel heard without immediately receiving advice, they experience a deep sense of relief and emotional safety," says Dr Amithabh. "Humans often instinctively respond to distress by offering solutions or quick fixes. But the urge to solve a problem at once can sometimes prevent us from truly listening and become a barrier to genuine connection."

Used in that way, AI can act as a sounding board. It can help someone slow down before sending an angry message, work through what they want to say, or find language for an emotion they have not yet understood. As Theertha says, "Sometimes I don't even need an answer. I just need to vent, or organise my thoughts."

The problem, however, begins when the 'comfort corner' replaces genuine interpersonal conversations altogether. "Human relationships are rarely seamless. People misunderstand, disagree, interrupt, and sometimes fail to respond in the way one hopes. They also have needs, boundaries, and bad days of their own," says psychiatrist and author Dr Arun B Nair. "A chatbot brings none of that friction. It remains available on the user's terms. It does not become offended or offer an inconvenient point of view unless

prompted to do so. That ease is also concerning."

Human communication, he says, involves far more than exchanging words. It requires people to read facial expressions, notice changes in tone, interpret body language, deal with disagreement, and respond to another person's emotions. "When we interact with humans, we learn to adjust, understand reactions, and correct our own behaviour. These experiences contribute to personality development and communication skills," he says. "AI can imitate the language of empathy, but it does not participate in a relationship in the human sense. It does not have perspectives shaped by lived experience."

This distinction becomes particularly important for children and teenagers, whose social skills are still developing. "When a child interacts only with a system that responds instantly and agrees easily, they may miss opportunities to develop the ability to handle different opinions and complex social situations," notes Dr Arun. "Only disagreements and awkward conversations teach young people how to apologise, wait, negotiate, manage frustration, and recognise another point of view."

The risk, therefore, is not merely that people may spend too much time chatting with AI. It is that they may begin to prefer relationships in which the other party makes no demands.

There is also the danger of handing over too much decision-making. A person may begin by asking AI how to word a message, then whether to send it, how to interpret the reply and what to do next. Over time, the chatbot can move from helping or organising thoughts to shaping choices that would otherwise require personal judgement or discussion with someone who understands the wider context.

Its confidence can also be misleading. An answer may sound reassuring even while being incomplete or wrong. Dr Arun cautions users against blindly going by AI responses. "Information should be checked against reliable sources, particularly when it concerns health, medication, money, education, or other important decisions," he stresses.

He also notes that cases of over-dependence on AI and excessive emotional bonding with bots are on the rise. "AI should be treated as a supportive tool, not as a substitute for human relationships," says Dr Arun. "Never confuse usefulness with friendship."

Gurjapneet Singh, NS Chaturvedi, M Karthik, G Periyaswamy. We have KB (Arun Karthik) as a coach who knows the team's brand of cricket. So we are confident of a good show," said Anirudh.

Madurai team also has a new owner, Palani Gurusamy, who has been a cricket aficionado, admiring the likes of Viv Richards and Kapil Dev. He launched the team jersey on Saturday in the presence of TJ Srinivasaraj, president, Tamil Nadu Cricket Association (TNCA). "I did not have any particular team in mind. I got to know about Madurai's availability for purchasing. Plus, my hometown is near Madurai. So, it suited my thoughts well. We immediately jumped into discussion and then struck a deal," said Palani, adding he may also invest in a

first state domestic league started by TNCA. It's well established. Other leagues, in other states are just starting now. But Tamil Nadu laid

the foundation very well and now it's been steady. We are confident that this league is going to be stronger in the coming years," he said, insisting that his team will also do well financially.

The TNPL will be played at Natham and Chepak. The second leg of the league and play-offs will be played in Chennai. "It's good that we will be playing in only two grounds. So now we can plan better. The plan is to take one match at a time and then capitalise on the momentum. We have some good all-rounders and Shaob (Mohammed Khan, batter) will have a big role to play. We have variety in our attack and some quality bowlers

der," shared Anirudh.

CSK ace bowler Gurjapneet is excited to play the TNPL and wants to give his best shot in the tournament that is dear to him as it served as a platform for him to play IPL. "We have a good side and certainly we will go all out to bag the trophy. Our batting and bowling both look very strong. We have a set of few senior players and the youngsters must match up nicely with them. They should also get a proper chance to play freely," said Gurjapneet.

TNPL is good preparation for the IPL. And if one looks at the trend in the Indian team, the management prefers all-rounders. "I am trying to improve as a batter with every outing. Batting is now important for every bowler, like you can just add a run; it's a bit for a team and it's very good, you will get X factor. So that's what I have been practising for the last two years, and I hope this year I will do well for my team," said Gurjapneet.

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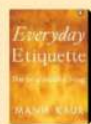
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BOOK NOOK



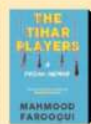
The Red Badge
By Rajesh R. Varma

Rajesh, the topper in a Malayalam-medium school in Tiruvalla, founded by his upper-caste Kshatriya ancestors, is excited to move to the big English-medium school there. But things go awry from here.



Everyday Etiquette: The Art of Mindful Living
By Manik Kaur

A heartfelt, practical guide to reclaiming the lost art of everyday grace — at home, online, and at work, in a world that is faster, louder, and increasingly distracted, and where small courtesies are disappearing.



The Tihar Players
By Mahmood Farooqui

None of the prisoners had acted, but they attend Mahmood Farooqui's drama class seeking respect and validation. And thus began the journey of a successful prison experiment.



Life in the time of Polycrisis
By G Madhusoodanan

The book unravels the fault lines in the Western socio-economic, environmental, energy, and climate policies that have landed the world in a polycrisis, the global climate crisis being its worst manifestation.



DR VIVEK ARORA
@vivekara@photos.com
The expert is a senior veterinarian, Crown Vet, Delhi.

FITBIT

WHY PUSH EXERCISES FEEL EASIER THAN PULL EXERCISES

If you've ever noticed that push-ups feel easier than pull-ups or that you can



RING OF FIRE

A dog showcases its skills at the Police Medal Presentation function held at Rajarathinam Stadium. | P JAYANAR

QUICKFIX

CHOCO-NUTTY

INGREDIENTS

- Dark chocolate: 200 g
- Sugar and walnuts: 2 cups
- Maida: 1/2 cup
- Cocoa powder and Vanilla: 1 tbsp
- Butter: 100 g
- Eggs: 2
- Salt: A pinch

METHOD

- Melt dark chocolate and butter together until smooth. Stir in sugar until well combined.
- Add eggs and vanilla; whisk until glossy. Fold in maida, cocoa powder, and a pinch of salt.
- Add chopped walnuts and pour the batter into a greased tray.
- Bake in a preheated oven at 180°C for 20–25 minutes.



Contributed by Sejal Sood, Bengaluru

My pet is turning nine and is startled by sudden sound. What can be done?

New tremors or an increased sensitivity to sound in a nine-year-old pet should be assessed by a veterinarian. These signs may be associated with anxiety, pain, age-related cognitive or hearing changes, metabolic problems, medication side effects, or a neurological condition. Try to record the episodes and note their triggers, frequency, duration, and your pet's responsiveness. Meanwhile, minimise sudden

ASK AN XPERT

noises and provide a calm, secure resting area. Your veterinarian may recommend ear and neurological examinations and blood tests. Seek urgent care if your pet develops seizures, collapse, weakness, disorientation, or loss of consciousness.



bench press more weight than you can row, you're not alone. Many people experience a difference between pushing and pulling strength, especially when they begin strength training. This is largely due to the way our muscles and joints are designed, along with how different movement patterns work. Understanding this difference can help you train more effectively and reduce muscle imbalances.

PUSH MUSCLES ARE GENERALLY STRONGER

Pushing exercises such as push-ups, bench presses, and shoulder presses mainly use the chest, shoulders, and triceps. These are large muscle groups that generate significant force and often work together during everyday activities, making pushing movements feel more comfortable for many people.

PULLING MOVEMENTS DEMAND MORE CONTROL

Exercises like pull-ups, rows, and lat pull-downs rely on the back, biceps, and muscles around the shoulder blades. These muscles not only produce force but also help stabilise the spine and shoulders. As a result, pulling exercises often require better coordination and technique, making them feel more challenging.

BODY POSITION AFFECTS PERFORMANCE

The position of your body changes how much effort an exercise requires. During a push-up, your body naturally creates a stable base to push against. In contrast, pull-ups and rows require you to move or support your body while pulling against gravity, increasing the demand on your muscles.

BUILD PULLING STRENGTH GRADUALLY

It's common for beginners to have stronger pushing muscles than pulling muscles. Rather than increasing the weight too quickly, focus on improving your pulling volume by adding a few extra repetitions or sets over time. Strengthening the back, biceps, and shoulder stabilisers can improve overall balance and movement quality.

TRAIN BOTH MOVEMENTS EQUALLY

A balanced workout should include both pushing and pulling exercises. Neglecting pulling movements may contribute to poor posture, shoulder discomfort, and muscle imbalances. Including rows, pull-downs, face pulls, and assisted pull-ups alongside pressing exercises helps develop more balanced upper-body strength.



By Chandana Jagadeeshan, fitness expert, Cult — a fitness and wellness platform

WHATWHENWHYWHERE

Wrapped in loom

The Amethyst Room presents Loom's Lullaby - The Song of the Loom, a showcase by Mako Textiles. The showcase features crafted women's wear, including tunics, pyjamas, trousers, saris, and scarves, along with a selection of men's wear.

WHEN: August 5-9



Lace up

Sneaker Fest has officially arrived at Phoenix Marketcity & Palladium Chennai, transforming the city's favourite shopping destination into the ultimate sneaker playground, with exclusive offers ranging from 30% to 70% across brands.

WHEN: Till August 8



A Thai fest

Park Hyatt Chennai welcomes discerning diners to experience the heart of Thailand through an exclusive five-night culinary residency featuring acclaimed Thai Chef Bussarin Choksin at The Flying Elephant.

WHEN: August 5-9
CALL: 893987277

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Party destination

Elevate your nightlife experience at Willows Bar at The Westin Chennai brings the city alive with electrifying DJ Nights from Tuesday to Sunday, 8 pm to 2 am. The weekly lineup includes, Ladies Night on Wednesdays, Retro Night on Thursdays, Tamil Night on Fridays, Bollywood Night on Saturdays, and International Beats on Sundays. For reservations: 8939892079



Start-up stories

LARK Circle is a curated gathering for founders, business owners, investors, operators, and ecosystem enablers who believe in meaningful conversations and building genuine connections. Join to exchange ideas, gain feedback, network and meet people who can help you, at Backyard, Adyar. Contact: 9385463673

WHEN: August 8, 6 pm - 8 pm



An extravagant exhibition

Kalkruthi presents Santhe, a ten-day product display, offering a spectacle wherein over 90 craft groups from 21 states would showcase their talent and wares that reflect the culture of our rich civilisation.

WHEN: Till August 9, 11 am to 7:30 pm
WHERE: GRV Mahal, Mambakkam Main Road, Medavakkam

Art narratives

Art Houz Chennai presents Silent Narratives, an art exhibition that explores the eloquence of the unspoken. Through layered compositions and evocative imagery, C. Douglas transforms memory, place, and the human condition into quiet visual meditations.

WHEN: Till August 8, 10 am to 6:30 pm



Murder Mystery night

Work with fellow participants, question suspects, piece together evidence, and solve an interactive murder mystery where every conversation could hold the next clue.

WHEN: August 8
WHERE: Backyard, Adyar



ARTCORNER



EARTH, METAL, MEMORY

Latika Katt's bronze cast is mounted with larger stones — like a relic placed in its reliquary.



Howl's Moving Castle

MANISHA V C S

FRAMES that turn reality into whimsy, characters that fly across the sky, so detailed and filled with warmth and colour that they perfectly blend reality with imagination...

It has been 40 years since Studio Ghibli's magic graced the silver screen for the first time.

On August 2, 1986, the wonders of this Japanese animation studio first hit theatres with their film *Castle in the Sky*. Directors Hayao Miyazaki and Isao Takahata, along with producer Toshio Suzuki, etched a new chapter in the history of anime, or perhaps art as a whole.

Set up in 1985, the anime revolution of Miyazaki and Co. began with the story of two orphaned teenagers in search of the flying city of Laputa. Drawing from Jonathan Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* and the quest literature of Jules Verne and RL Stevenson, the film was not a commercial success upon its release.

The turning point for the filmmakers came in 1988, when they released two of their most revered films, *Grave of the Fireflies* and *My Neighbour Totoro*. The former told a heart-breaking story of grief against the backdrop of World War II. And *Totoro*, the studio's most beloved film, eternalised a large and gentle forest spirit. Fans received both films with open arms.

Then came *Kiki's Delivery Service*, giving voice to the worries of young girls leaving home for new towns. That is the magic of Ghibli. Through picturesque frames and colourful art, they weave tales of ordinary people and their lives. Joe Hisaishi's baroque and jazz styles music complements the charm of Ghibliverse.

In the 2001 Oscar-winning film *Spirited Away*, Miyazaki unveils the wonders of a magical world where



Still from 'My Neighbour Totoro'



'Spirited Away'

spirits dwell. Through young girl Chihiro and her dragon companion Haku, the animation extravaganza speaks about social issues in a rapidly urbanising world through whimsical characters and settings.

In their fairly simplistic film *The Wind Rises*, the creators drew a biopic of renowned Japanese aeronautical engineer Jiro Horikoshi, depicting his struggles and successes against the backdrop of Japan's pre-war industrial development.



Still from 'Castle in the Sky', the first film made by Studio Ghibli

As Studio Ghibli celebrated its 40th anniversary of its first film on August 2, CE zooms in on the enduring appeal of Ghibli movies and how they revolutionised the animation industry



Whisper of the Heart

he says.

"Their success lies in the honesty of its storytelling. They go beyond the struggles of commercial appeal, bringing in unconventional styles and personal attributes," he notes. "In most of their films, they bring in child characters and show us how they respectfully deal with them."

They also understood that politics and philosophy equally appeal to both children and adults."

Echoing the admiration, award-winning animator and Studio Eeksa-

rus founder Suresh Eriyart terms Studio Ghibli as "a huge personal inspiration".

"It lit a spark in us to set up our own studio," he adds. "I also have a personal connection with Studio Ghibli. Back in 2016, I was invited to present our stop-motion animation film *Tokri* at the Ghibli Museum. It was one of the biggest fanboy experiences for me. Last year, I was invited as a jury member at the Tokyo Anime Award Festival and visited Studio Ghibli. During that visit, I also had the unforgettable opportunity to meet Miyazaki."

The tradition continues. A prime example is the recent film *Banana*. Director Chidambaram S Podaval attributed the inspiration behind several scenic frames in the film to his love for Studio Ghibli.

The wonders of Ghibli, clearly, continue to capture the love of generations of fans worldwide. Be it through film frames or just an AI-made social media DP.

JUST PLAY

Pleasure sans purpose



VINITA SIDHARTHA
vinita@kreedagames.com or vinita@sidhartha.in

The writer is the founder of Kreed, an organisation reviving traditional games

A short while ago, diversions due to Metro work rerouted main road traffic through my neighbourhood. Every day, as I negotiate the pell-mell on our road, I am reminded of the sleepy neighbourhood with beautiful trees where a car would pass by once every hour or so. And our joys knew no bounds when the government filled an empty ground with sand to stop water stagnation. Children learned to cycle, cricket matches were played, and once in a while, a game of badminton, too. They played made-up games on abandoned plots and searched for fake treasures under overgrown bushes. In a large clearing at the meeting point of three roads, a game of *Pittu* or Seven Stones was in progress. *Pittu* is a game of every type were drawn on the road. The chalk lines that remained for days were a testament to the unfettered spaces.

We celebrate roads, bridges, and buildings. But what about the informal infrastructure that were pillars of childhood? A shady tree. A compound wall. A broad pavement. A temple *mandapam*. A vacant plot. None were built as play spaces, yet all became important civic assets.

I am often asked why children don't play anymore; why they are glued to their devices. As spaces disappear, play disappears too. Traffic makes streets unsafe and impractical for a sustained game. Vacant plots have become dumping grounds for apartments watched over by guards, rarely allowing neighbourhood children to gather and play. So where do children play?

One might argue that most neighbourhoods have a playground or park, which is true. However, most playgrounds are taken over by older children and parks have become the

noise and running around or a flying ball. Even those available may not be always easily accessible for young children. It simply is not as easy as stepping out of your home. Children who gather to play often, have little else in common — different ages, different schools, different social backgrounds. The game becomes the reason to build communities.

Play needs not only playgrounds, but places where children are allowed to linger. A corner where they can pause after school. A street that is not immediately hostile. A bit of shade where one can sit and talk. A courtyard where the adults do not have to constantly say, "Don't run". These are not spectacular spaces, but ordinary and almost invisible ones. And childhood has always made use of the ordinary.

These spaces do not require expensive equipments. It can limit play. Unlike a swing or a slide, an open ground or a spreading tree invites invention. It can be a house, a fort, a shop, a battlefield, a cricket ground, a kingdom. Children just need space, time, and company.

Perhaps what we have lost is not only land, but tolerance. The tolerance for noise, chalk marks, dust, quarrels that are forgotten in five minutes, balls that stray into verandas, and children who take up space without a defined purpose. We have become very good at assigning use. But play slips through all neat categories. It thrives where a place is allowed to be a little undefined.

When children are allowed to gather without a purpose, something gentle happens — someone watches, someone joins, someone teaches the rules, someone invents a new one. A game begins without announcement and dissolves just as easily. No one may think of this as community building, but that is exactly what it is. The city, for a little while, becomes less private and more shared.

If we want children to play again, we may need to do more than build playgrounds. We may need to make room for the unplanned, the informal, and the wonderfully purposeless. So, I ask again, where have the

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE

EVEN before stepping into Kamarajar Arangam on Friday, the celebration of arts and culture had already begun on the sidelines. The foyer buzzed with students in costumes rehearsing their final steps, teachers hurried between dressing areas, and parents stood in a corner catching one last glimpse of their little ones before the grand showcase. By the time the auditorium doors opened, every seat had been claimed by eager families, alumni, faculty members and students, for Abhinaya 2026, the 69th anniversary celebration of the Padma Seshadri Bala Bhavan (PSBB) Group of Schools. Hosted by the Nungambakkam campus on July 31 and the KK Nagar campus on August 1, the annual event revolved around the theme 'Kaatrin Mozhi' (The Language of Air), interpreting the founder Dr (Mrs) YG Parthasarathy's philosophy of AIR — Accountability,

MOULDING MASTERY IN YOUNG MINDS

Integrity and Responsibility — through diverse music, dance, and theatre performances.

The celebration was graced by Padma Shri recipients and Carnatic musicians Ranjani and Gayatri (the RaGans sisters) on the opening day, while Subhasree Thanickachalam, creative head at Ragamika TV, music analyst, curator, and presenter, was the chief guest on Saturday.

Appreciating the efforts and energy poured into the event, Ranjani reflected, "This is what a community built on commitment, love, and discipline looks like. It is wonderful to see the kind of breadth of activities that the school is carrying and how beautifully all these young minds are shaped and nurtured."

Gayatri urged students to value perseverance over perfection. "We are musicians, and music has taught us one beautiful but very brutal truth — there are no shortcuts, not even one." She acknowledged how every song that they excel at was once sung badly with mistakes, but repetition and labour made them who they are today. She added, "That is the real secret behind every excellent thing that you have ever seen and that you will ever see. A missed note, a low mark, a forgotten line — none of this is the end of the story. The only true failure is that you have never tried."

Dean, director and correspondent Sheela Rajendra explained the significance of the theme. "During this

centenary year of our beloved Mrs YGP, it was only appropriate that we chose 'Kaatrin Mozhi' and her mantra, AIR. Just as fresh and clean air is important for our very existence, she always believed that these values are equally important in both our private and professional lives." Nearly 1,000 students were part of the event, including the back-end work of prop-making, voice recording, etc.

The students performed musical synergy on wind instruments, dance theatre on the shared responsibility of preservation of air, and moved on to devotional storytelling. The grand finale 'Navaras Pavanah', conceptual dance performance, brought the ancient yogic understanding of *rayu* (air) through human emotions. While the parents of children from the school's Nungambakkam, T Nagar, and Siruseri branches witnessed the show on Friday, the show on Saturday was dedicated to the parents from KK Nagar branch.

FOREVER FRIENDS

Give these lives a second chance. Make them believe that a beautiful life awaits them.



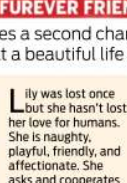
These four-week-old kittens are healthy, playful, and very friendly.



Luna is a rescued black lab full of love, loyalty, and gratitude. This 2-3 years old pup is a gentle soul who is neutered and vaccinated.



Bella is a sweet-natured Chippiparai who is looking for her forever home. She is three years old, vaccinated, and spayed.



Lily was lost once but she hasn't lost her love for humans. She is naughty, playful, friendly, and affectionate. She asks and cooperates when needed, and loves human company.



Aju and Shalilu are two little hearts up for adoption.



Three abandoned newborn kittens need a safe place. They will be vaccinated before adoption. They have been eating dry and wet food.

These two little semi-Persian kittens are up for adoption. They are 45 days old and litter trained.

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4

AKSHAY KUMAR

NATIONAL Award-winning documentary *Life in Loom* was an unexpected detour for its producer, Francis Markus, and director, Edmond Ranson. With both nurturing ambitions in feature films, a documentary on India's weavers was definitely not a part of their plans. What began in 2018 as an attempt to examine the impact of climate change on weaving soon unravelled into a much larger story encompassing livelihoods, socio-economic pressures and even geopolitics. The journey took the team across seven regions of India, as they successfully faced production challenges, the pandemic and dwindling resources. If the already arduous journey wasn't enough, even the appreciation came with a caveat: Do not make documentaries on 'dry subjects' like weaving.

The perseverance eventually paid off when *Life in Loom* won the National Award, bringing renewed attention to the people and craft. In a conversation with CE, producer Francis Markus, founder of Mark Studios, reflects on the film's long journey, what it taught him about India's weaving communities, and why documentary storytelling matters.

Excerpts:

Q Given that both you and director Edmond wanted to make a mark in films, why did you go with a documentary?

Honestly, no idea. I worked as an assistant director in *Velayudham* and *Jilla*, and Edmond, my college junior, worked as an AD in *Azadi*. One day, he met me with this idea in 2018. He was so confident about portraying the problems faced by weavers across India. I too felt I had to back this project. Interestingly, we initially planned how climate change is impacting weavers, but as we got to know more about their lives, the documentary just branched out to more and more problems in their profession. After a point, we strug-



gled not knowing how much to tell and where to restrict.

Q How did *Life in Loom* branch out, and what took this long for the documentary to be about?

Edmond first planned to shoot in four regions, then I extended it to more, and we fixed it at seven. I didn't want half-hearted efforts. I was in for a shock after Edmond returned after travelling across India, as the footage was episodic. Meaning, Tamil Nadu, Leh, Assam, etc..... They were impactful in isolation. But there



Francis Markus



was a risk of people stopping it with one episode/region. I did not want that. So I wanted a thread to tie all the stories together and package it as one project. I sent Edmond again on a trip, then Covid happened. Despite the pandemic and resources drying up, fortunately, we got what we wanted. Our original footage was over three hours long. We were able to make it crispier, and the run time came down to 100 minutes. The satisfying end product made us forget the hiccups we went through while making it.

Q Take us through your National Award journey.

The very day I decided to make this documentary, I came to terms with the fact that there is no way I will get any return on investment. The only takeaway from *Life in Loom* for me is

the recognition. So I decided to take the film through the festival circuit. Screenings and accolades at IFFI Goa opened a lot of doors for me, and then the Mumbai International Film Festival. Not just appreciation, but advice too was unanimous. I was told weaving was a very dry subject with hardly any takers. Also, I was egged on to make a feature film next time. It was after the eye-opening conversations I had there with people that I decided to take the film to the National Awards. We did not make *Life in Loom* with any award in mind. But I take this

opportunity to thank the jury and the people, as the National Award has suddenly turned the gaze towards our documentary.

Q Why do you think documentary filmmaking is necessary even after going through so much?

From theatre, the storytelling has morphed into the microdrama format today, and I have no idea what it will become in the future. Instead of helping increase people's attention span, the market is catering to their diminishing attention. So the habit of reading is also in decline. Documentary, I feel, has become the only way to impart information and to transfer our culture, stories, and struggles to the next generation. Important information coming out as a hero's punch line in a star vehicle only has the shelf life of a clap or a whistle. What stays with them is only the star-craze. That is why I feel documentary storytelling is imperative.

Q Your plans with *Life in Loom* after the National Award win?

The National Award win gives me an impetus to take the documentary to the masses. I am planning a screening soon. India is the global textile hub; we have such creative weavers here. Whenever a model or an influencer wears a saree, we admire their beauty. We don't think of the craft that went into it and the master craftsman behind it. After you watch *Life in Loom*, you will begin appreciating the hardworking weavers. More than anything else, they are our people; if we don't tell their stories, then who will?

WEAVING TALES

Life in Loom producer Francis Markus shares his route to the National Award win, revelations about weavers' hardships, necessity for documentary filmmaking, and more



A still from Life in Loom

TIGER SHROFF TO TEAM UP WITH REMO D'SOUZA

ON Friday, producer Vicky Jain announced the launch of his new production house VJ Frames, while sharing details of the first project under the banner. Vicky has signed Tiger Shroff for an ambitious action entertainer, which is set to be directed by choreographer-filmmaker Remo D'Souza.

The yet-to-be-titled project will also feature Abhishek Bachchan-starrer *Be Happy* (2025). Tiger Shroff, meanwhile, was last seen in *Baaghi 4* (2025). His upcoming projects include *Lag Ja Gale*, which also stars Jhanvi Kapoor and Lakshya.

tion between Remo and Tiger after *Flying Jatt* (2016). Remo last directed the Abhishek Bachchan-starrer *Be Happy* (2025). Tiger Shroff, meanwhile, was last seen in *Baaghi 4* (2025). His upcoming projects include *Lag Ja Gale*, which also stars Jhanvi Kapoor and Lakshya.



DSP to compose for Karthi 30

ACTOR Karthi's milestone 30th film has added another major name to its crew. On the occasion of composer Devi Sri Prasad's birthday on Sunday, the makers officially announced that he will be scoring the music for the upcoming entertainer.

The film marks the composer's first collaboration with director Kalyan Shankar, known for *Mad* (2023) and *Mad Square* (2025). The yet-to-be-titled film, backed by Sithara Entertainment, was officially launched with a pooja ceremony on Karthi's birthday back in May. The film stars Meenakshi Chaudhary as the female lead, marking her first on-screen pairing with Karthi. She was



last seen in Vijay's *The Greatest of All Time (GOAT)*.

Meanwhile, Karthi is also awaiting the release of *Sardar 2*, slated for September 10. He also has *Marshall*, directed by Taaanakkaran filmmaker

Tamizh. Set in the period drama co-stars Kalyani Priyadarshan, Sathyaaraj, Prabhu, Lal, John Kokken and Eswari Rao.



RJ Mahvash to star in Ragini 3

ACTOR-producer RJ Mahvash recently took



READY or Not star Samara Weaving is all set to enter the MCU as a mutant. She has been cast as the X-Men character Emma Frost. The Marvel character is

Rebecca Hall joins The Secrets of Secrets

WE previously reported that Morgan Spector will star as Robert Langdon in Netflix's series adaptation of Dan Brown's novel *The Secret of Secrets*. The latest update is that actor and Spector's wife Rebecca Hall will star opposite him.

Hall is best known for *The Prestige* (2006), *Vicky Cristina Barcelona* (2008), *The Town* (2010), *Iron Man 3* (2013), *The Gift* (2015) and *Passing* (2021). She has had two releases so far in 2026: *The Man I Love* and *The End of It*. Her upcoming films include *Onslaught* and *A Head Full of Ghosts*. She is currently starring in the sci-fi body horror series *The Beauty: The Secret of Secrets* is created by Brown and Carlton Cuse, who



As to her social media to announce her next project. She will be sharing screen space with Tamannaah and Junaid Khan in *Ragini 3*. Produced by Ekta Kapoor, and directed by Shashanka Ghosh, the film also stars Aayush Sharma. *Ragini 3* is the third entry in the *MMS* horror franchise, which had its first outing in 2011 starring Rajkumar Rao and Kainaz Motivala. It was followed by *Ragini MMS 2* in 2014, starring Sunny Leone. Mahvash made her acting debut last year with the OTT series *Pyaar Paisa Profit*.



Samara Weaving enters the MCU

part of the *Electric Blue*, an alternative group to Charles Xavier's X-Men, often going up against the latter. The character is a telepath like Xavier, but she is also able to transform her physical body into a fully diamond form, making her indestructible in that form. The upcoming untitled X-Men film will be directed by Jake Schreier, who has previously directed Marvel's *Thunderbolts* (2025). Weaving recently reprised the role of Grace MacCaulley in *Ready or Not 2: Here I Come*, a sequel to 2019's *Ready or Not*. She was also seen in *Over Your Dead Body*.

have previously created *Tom Clancy's Jack Ryan*.

